

★ THE TRIVIA SERIES — BOOK 2 ★

UNBELIEVABLE BUT TRUE TRIVIA

*630 Questions · 14 Chapters · Facts That Will Change What
You Think You Know*

Rounds: Fact Reveal · True or False · Multiple Choice · Quick Fire ·
Stump Your Friends!

Ahmad Asad

The Trivia Series

Unbelievable But True Trivia

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Answer Keys

Score Summary & Knowledge Rank

Total questions: **630** · Points available: **630** · Chapters: **14**

How This Book Works

This is not a standard trivia book. Each chapter begins by **showing you ten astonishing facts** — then immediately tests whether those facts sank in. After the fact-based rounds, harder questions expand your knowledge even further.

ROUND 1 FACT BOMBS

10 stunning facts. Read them carefully — your next rounds depend on remembering them.

ROUND 2 TRUE OR FALSE (10 pts)

10 statements based directly on the Fact Bombs. Did you take note?

ROUND 3 COULD YOU HAVE GUESSED? (10 pts)

10 multiple choice questions on the facts revealed. Four options, one answer.

ROUND 4 QUICK FIRE (10 pts)

10 short-answer questions on the chapter theme. No options. Pure recall.

ROUND 5 STUMP YOUR FRIENDS! (15 pts)

15 harder multiple choice questions — the round that separates the curious from the knowledgeable.

TOTAL PER CHAPTER 45 points (10+10+10+15 scored rounds).
Grand total: 630 points across 14 chapters.

KNOWLEDGE RANK TABLE

567–630 ★★★★★ GRAND MASTER — You know things that most people refuse to believe.

504–566 ★★★★★ KNOWLEDGE CHAMPION — Outstanding across every subject.

378–503 ★★★★★ CURIOUS SCHOLAR — Strong foundations with serious depth.

252–377 ★★★★★ KEEN LEARNER — Good instincts. Read more, return, beat your score.

Below 252 ★★★★★ APPRENTICE — Everyone starts here. The facts are waiting for you.

CHAPTER 01 • UNBELIEVABLE BUT TRUE TRIVIA

The Animal Kingdom

You think you know animals. You don't.

ROUND 1 — FACT BOMBS

Read these 10 astonishing facts carefully. Your next rounds will test whether they landed.

FACT #1

A group of flamingos is called a "flamboyance." A group of owls is called a "parliament."

★ *Even bird group names have personality.*

FACT #2

Octopuses have three hearts — two pump blood to the gills; one pumps it to the body. When they swim, the body heart stops beating.

★ *Which is why they prefer crawling.*

FACT #3

A snail can sleep for up to three years at a time during periods of drought.

★ *The ultimate power nap.*

FACT #4

Crows can recognise human faces and will remember — and hold grudges against — people who have wronged them.

★ *Never anger a crow.*

FACT #5

Wombats produce cube-shaped droppings — the only animal on Earth to do so. They use them to mark territory.

★ *Nature's most unique packaging.*

FACT #6

Mantis shrimps can punch with the force of a bullet and see 16 types of colour receptors. Humans have three.

★ *The most visually advanced animal alive.*

FACT #7

Elephants are the only animals that cannot jump. They are also one of only a few species that mourn their dead.

★ *They hold ceremonies at the bones of lost family members.*

FACT #8

The pistol shrimp can snap its claw so fast it creates a cavitation bubble reaching 8,000°F — briefly hotter than the surface of the Sun.

★ *A shrimp that produces a tiny sun.*

FACT #9

Dolphins sleep with one eye open and one brain hemisphere active at a time, allowing them to watch for predators while resting.

★ *Half asleep is still too smart for you.*

FACT #10

Tardigrades — microscopic water bears — can survive in outer space, volcanic vents, the Mariana Trench, and the vacuum of space.

★ *The most indestructible life form on Earth.*

ROUND 2**True or False** (10 statements based on the Fact Bombs • 1 pt each)

Mark each TRUE or FALSE — all answers relate to the facts you just read.

1. A group of owls is called a parliament.
TRUE / FALSE
2. Octopuses have two hearts.
TRUE / FALSE
3. Snails can sleep for up to three years.
TRUE / FALSE
4. Crows cannot recognise individual human faces.
TRUE / FALSE
5. Wombats produce cube-shaped droppings.
TRUE / FALSE
6. Mantis shrimps have three types of colour receptors, the same as humans.
TRUE / FALSE
7. Elephants are among the few animals that mourn their dead.
TRUE / FALSE
8. The pistol shrimp's cavitation bubble is hotter than the surface of the Sun.
TRUE / FALSE
9. Dolphins sleep with both hemispheres of the brain active simultaneously.
TRUE / FALSE
10. Tardigrades can survive in outer space.
TRUE / FALSE

ROUND 3**Could You Have Guessed?** (10 multiple choice questions • 1 pt each)

Four options — only one is correct.

1. How many hearts does an octopus have?
 - A. One
 - B. Two
 - C. Three

D. Four

2. What is a group of flamingos called?

- A. A bloom
- B. A flamboyance
- C. A parade
- D. A shimmer

3. How many colour receptor types does a mantis shrimp have?

- A. 3
- B. 8
- C. 12
- D. 16

4. Which animal produces cube-shaped droppings?

- A. Platypus
- B. Wombat
- C. Echidna
- D. Cassowary

5. Which animal cannot jump?

- A. Hippo
- B. Rhino
- C. Elephant
- D. Giraffe

6. What does a pistol shrimp create when it snaps its claw?

- A. A sonic boom
- B. A flash of light
- C. A cavitation bubble
- D. An electric shock

7. How long can a snail sleep during drought?

- A. Six months
- B. One year
- C. Two years
- D. Three years

8. What makes tardigrades remarkable?

- A. They have no DNA
- B. They can survive in space
- C. They live for 500 years
- D. They photosynthesize

9. Crows are known to do what with people who wronged them?

- A. Attack instantly
- B. Steal their food
- C. Hold grudges and remember faces
- D. Mimic their voices

10. How do dolphins sleep?

- A. They don't sleep
- B. One eye open, one brain hemisphere active
- C. Both eyes closed, drifting
- D. Floating vertically

ROUND 4**Quick Fire (10 short-answer questions · 1 pt each)**

No options. Write your answer from memory.

- 1.** What is the world's largest land animal?

Answer:

- 2.** What is a baby kangaroo called?

Answer:

- 3.** Which is the only mammal capable of true powered flight?

Answer:

- 4.** What is the fastest land animal?

Answer:

- 5.** A group of crows is called a what?

Answer:

- 6.** Which animal has the highest blood pressure?

Answer:

- 7.** How many legs does a spider have?

Answer:

- 8.** What is the largest species of shark?

Answer:

- 9.** Which country has the most venomous snakes?

Answer:

- 10.** What do pandas almost exclusively eat?

Answer:

ROUND 5**Stump Your Friends! (15 harder questions · 1 pt each)**

The round that separates the curious from the truly knowledgeable. No mercy.

- 1. How many brains does an octopus effectively have (central + arm ganglia)?**
 - A. One
 - B. Three
 - C. Five
 - D. Nine
- 2. What temperature does a pistol shrimp's cavitation bubble briefly reach?**
 - A. 1,000°F
 - B. 4,000°F
 - C. 8,000°F
 - D. 20,000°F
- 3. What percentage of their time do koalas spend sleeping?**
 - A. 50%
 - B. 65%
 - C. 75%
 - D. 80%
- 4. Which bird has the largest wingspan?**
 - A. Condor
 - B. Eagle
 - C. Albatross
 - D. Pelican
- 5. A starfish has no brain and no blood. What flows through its body instead?**
 - A. Lymph fluid
 - B. Sea water
 - C. A salt solution
 - D. Oxygen-rich plasma
- 6. How many ants are estimated to exist on Earth?**
 - A. 1 trillion
 - B. 10 trillion
 - C. 20 quadrillion
 - D. 100 quadrillion
- 7. What is the scientific term for the fear of animals?**
 - A. Zoophobia

- B. Animaphobia
 - C. Faunaphobia
 - D. Bestiphobia
- 8. Which is the only bird that can fly backwards?**
- A. Kingfisher
 - B. Hummingbird
 - C. Swift
 - D. Swallow
- 9. Crocodiles are more closely related to which animal?**
- A. Lizards
 - B. Snakes
 - C. Birds
 - D. Turtles
- 10. The blue whale's heart is approximately the size of:**
- A. A basketball
 - B. A car
 - C. A golf cart
 - D. A small room
- 11. Which animal has the longest gestation period?**
- A. Elephant (22 months)
 - B. Blue whale (11 months)
 - C. Giraffe (15 months)
 - D. Rhino (16 months)
- 12. What is a group of jellyfish called?**
- A. A bloom
 - B. A swarm
 - C. A cloud
 - D. A pulse
- 13. How do butterflies taste their food?**
- A. With antennae
 - B. With their proboscis
 - C. Through their feet
 - D. Through photoreceptors
- 14. Which fish can change its sex during its lifetime?**
- A. Salmon
 - B. Clownfish
 - C. Tuna
 - D. Swordfish

15. What is the lifespan of a mayfly as an adult?

- A. One day
- B. One week
- C. One hour
- D. 24 hours or less

MY SCORE: Round 1: ____/10 Round 2: ____/10 Round 3: ____/10
Round 4: ____/10 **TOTAL: ____/45**

CHAPTER CLOSE *Animals are far stranger than any science fiction writer has imagined. The natural world is four billion years of experimentation. Everything you just read is the result of evolution solving a problem in the most outrageous way possible.*

CHAPTER 1 — ANSWER KEY

Round 2 — True or False

1. A group of owls is called a parliament.... → **TRUE**
2. Octopuses have two hearts.... → **FALSE**
3. Snails can sleep for up to three years.... → **TRUE**
4. Crows cannot recognise individual human faces.... → **FALSE**
5. Wombats produce cube-shaped droppings.... → **TRUE**
6. Mantis shrimps have three types of colour receptors, the sam... → **FALSE**
7. Elephants are among the few animals that mourn their dead.... → **TRUE**
8. The pistol shrimp's cavitation bubble is hotter than the sur... → **TRUE**
9. Dolphins sleep with both hemispheres of the brain active sim... → **FALSE**
10. Tardigrades can survive in outer space.... → **TRUE**

Round 3 — Could You Have Guessed?

1. How many hearts does an octopus have? → **C. Three**
2. What is a group of flamingos called? → **B. A flamboyance**
3. How many colour receptor types does a mantis shrimp hav → **D. 16**
4. Which animal produces cube-shaped droppings? → **B. Wombat**
5. Which animal cannot jump? → **C. Elephant**
6. What does a pistol shrimp create when it snaps its claw → **C. A cavitation bubble**
7. How long can a snail sleep during drought? → **D. Three years**
8. What makes tardigrades remarkable? → **B. They can survive in space**
9. Crows are known to do what with people who wronged them → **C. Hold grudges and remember faces**
10. How do dolphins sleep? → **B. One eye open, one brain hemisphere active**

Round 4 — Quick Fire

1. What is the world's largest land animal? → **African elephant**
2. What is a baby kangaroo called? → **A joey**
3. Which is the only mammal capable of true powered flight? → **Bat**
4. What is the fastest land animal? → **Cheetah**
5. A group of crows is called a what? → **A murder**
6. Which animal has the highest blood pressure? → **Giraffe**
7. How many legs does a spider have? → **Eight**
8. What is the largest species of shark? → **Whale shark**
9. Which country has the most venomous snakes? → **Australia**
10. What do pandas almost exclusively eat? → **Bamboo**

Round 5 — Stump Your Friends!

1. How many brains does an octopus effectively have (centr → **D. Nine**
2. What temperature does a pistol shrimp's cavitation bubb → **C. 8,000°F**
3. What percentage of their time do koalas spend sleeping? → **D. 80%**
4. Which bird has the largest wingspan? → **C. Albatross**
5. A starfish has no brain and no blood. What flows throug → **B. Sea water**
6. How many ants are estimated to exist on Earth? → **C. 20 quadrillion**
7. What is the scientific term for the fear of animals? → **A. Zoophobia**
8. Which is the only bird that can fly backwards? → **B. Hummingbird**
9. Crocodiles are more closely related to which animal? → **C. Birds**
10. The blue whale's heart is approximately the size of: → **B. A car**
11. Which animal has the longest gestation period? → **A. Elephant (22 months)**
12. What is a group of jellyfish called? → **A. A bloom**
13. How do butterflies taste their food? → **C. Through their feet**
14. Which fish can change its sex during its lifetime? → **B. Clownfish**
15. What is the lifespan of a mayfly as an adult? → **D. 24 hours or less**

CHAPTER 02 • UNBELIEVABLE BUT TRUE TRIVIA

The Human Body

You've lived in your body your entire life. Almost none of what follows will be what you expected.

ROUND 1 — FACT BOMBS

Read these 10 astonishing facts carefully. Your next rounds will test whether they landed.

FACT #1

Your body produces about 25 million new cells every second. You replace most of your body's cells within seven to ten years.

★ *You are not the same person you were a decade ago — literally.*

FACT #2

The human eye can detect a single photon of light in complete darkness. You are essentially built with night-vision equipment.

★ *You're more sensitive than any camera ever made.*

FACT #3

Stomach acid (pH 1–2) is strong enough to dissolve razor blades. Your stomach replaces its lining every three to four days to avoid digesting itself.

★ *Your stomach would eat itself if it stopped trying.*

FACT #4

Humans are bioluminescent — we emit a faint visible light too dim to see with the naked eye. Our glow fluctuates throughout the day.

★ *You are literally glowing right now.*

FACT #5

The human brain generates enough electricity to power a small LED bulb — approximately 20 watts of electrical power continuously.

★ *A living light bulb, running nonstop for decades.*

FACT #6

Your nose can detect approximately one trillion different smells — not 10,000 as was previously believed. The 2014 science proved the old number wildly wrong.

★ *You've been underselling your nose for years.*

FACT #7

Blood vessels in a human body, if laid end to end, would stretch approximately 100,000 kilometres — enough to circle the Earth two and a half times.

★ *You contain a circulatory motorway system.*

FACT #8

The cornea of the human eye is the only tissue in the body that gets its oxygen directly from the air, not from blood. It has no blood vessels.

★ *Your eye breathes independently of your body.*

FACT #9

Goosebumps are a leftover evolutionary response from when humans had more body hair. They were designed to make fur stand up and trap warmth — or make us look bigger to predators.

★ *Your skin is still following instructions from a hairier ancestor.*

FACT #10

The human liver can regenerate itself from as little as 25% of its original tissue. It is the only internal organ with this capability.

★ *A built-in self-repair system that even surgeons rely on.*

ROUND 2**True or False (10 statements based on the Fact Bombs • 1 pt each)**

Mark each TRUE or FALSE — all answers relate to the facts you just read.

- 1.** The human body replaces most of its cells within seven to ten years.

TRUE / FALSE

- 2.** The human eye can detect a single photon of light.

TRUE / FALSE

- 3.** Stomach acid can dissolve razor blades.

TRUE / FALSE

- 4.** Humans emit visible light detectable by the naked eye.

TRUE / FALSE

- 5.** The human brain generates approximately 20 watts of electrical power.

TRUE / FALSE

- 6.** Humans can distinguish approximately 10,000 different smells.

TRUE / FALSE

- 7.** Blood vessels in the human body would circle the Earth roughly two and a half times.

TRUE / FALSE

- 8.** The cornea gets oxygen from blood like all other body tissues.

TRUE / FALSE

- 9.** Goosebumps are a remnant from when humans had more body hair.

TRUE / FALSE

- 10.** The liver can regenerate from as little as 25% of its tissue.

TRUE / FALSE

ROUND 3**Could You Have Guessed? (10 multiple choice questions • 1 pt each)**

Four options — only one is correct.

- 1.** How many new cells does your body produce per second?

- A. 1 million
 - B. 10 million
 - C. 25 million
 - D. 1 billion
- 2. What is the approximate pH of stomach acid?**
- A. 3–4
 - B. 1–2
 - C. 5–6
 - D. 7
- 3. How much electrical power does the human brain generate?**
- A. 5 watts
 - B. 20 watts
 - C. 50 watts
 - D. 100 watts
- 4. How many smells can the human nose detect?**
- A. 10,000
 - B. 100,000
 - C. 500,000
 - D. One trillion
- 5. How long are human blood vessels if laid end to end?**
- A. 10,000 km
 - B. 50,000 km
 - C. 100,000 km
 - D. 500,000 km
- 6. How often does the stomach replace its lining?**
- A. Every day
 - B. Every 3–4 days
 - C. Every week
 - D. Every month
- 7. Which is the only tissue with no blood vessels that gets O₂ directly from air?**
- A. Skin
 - B. Cartilage
 - C. Cornea
 - D. Eardrum
- 8. What percentage of its tissue can the liver regenerate from?**

- A. 10%
 - B. 25%
 - C. 50%
 - D. 75%
- 9. What were goosebumps originally designed to do?**
- A. Cool the body
 - B. Trap warmth and look bigger
 - C. Signal emotion
 - D. Protect nerve endings
- 10. How many chromosomes do humans have?**
- A. 23
 - B. 44
 - C. 46
 - D. 48

ROUND 4**Quick Fire (10 short-answer questions · 1 pt each)**

No options. Write your answer from memory.

- 1.** What is the largest organ in the human body?

Answer:

- 2.** What is the medical term for the kneecap?

Answer:

- 3.** Which blood type is the universal donor?

Answer:

- 4.** How many bones are in the adult human body?

Answer:

- 5.** What connects muscle to bone?

Answer:

- 6.** Which organ produces insulin?

Answer:

- 7.** What is the outer layer of skin called?

Answer:

- 8.** How many chambers does the heart have?

Answer:

- 9.** What is the hardest substance in the human body?

Answer:

- 10.** How long does a red blood cell live approximately?

Answer:

ROUND 5**Stump Your Friends! (15 harder questions · 1 pt each)**

The round that separates the curious from the truly knowledgeable. No mercy.

- 1. How many muscles does the face use to produce a smile (approximately)?**
 - A. 6
 - B. 12
 - C. 17
 - D. 43
- 2. What percentage of the human genome is shared with a banana?**
 - A. 15%
 - B. 30%
 - C. 50%
 - D. 60%
- 3. The human body has more bacterial cells than human cells. Approximately how many times more?**
 - A. Same amount
 - B. 3 times more
 - C. 10 times more
 - D. They're roughly equal with slight bacterial majority
- 4. How long would it take to fall asleep if you have sleep deprivation? (normal is 10–15 minutes)**
 - A. Under 30 seconds
 - B. Under 5 minutes
 - C. Under 2 minutes
 - D. Under 1 minute
- 5. The surface area of human lungs, if spread flat, would be approximately:**
 - A. Same as a door
 - B. Same as a tennis court
 - C. Same as a football field
 - D. Same as a small room
- 6. Which part of the body has the most nerve endings per square centimetre?**
 - A. Tongue
 - B. Fingertips
 - C. Lips
 - D. Cornea

7. How many times does the heart beat in an average lifetime?

- A. 500 million
- B. 1 billion
- C. 2.5 billion
- D. 5 billion

8. The human small intestine is approximately how long?

- A. 2–3 metres
- B. 4–5 metres
- C. 6–7 metres
- D. 8–9 metres

9. What percentage of the human brain is water?

- A. 55%
- B. 65%
- C. 73%
- D. 85%

10. Which chemical makes chillies hot?

- A. Capsaicin
- B. Piperine
- C. Allicin
- D. Quercetin

11. A human sneeze travels at approximately what speed?

- A. 50 mph
- B. 100 mph
- C. 160 mph
- D. 200 mph

12. The total length of nerves in the human body is approximately:

- A. 10 km
- B. 45 km
- C. 75 km
- D. 100 km

13. How many taste buds does the average adult have?

- A. 2,000
- B. 5,000
- C. 10,000

D. 50,000

14. What is the only muscle that never tires?

- A. Tongue
- B. Diaphragm
- C. Heart
- D. Jaw muscle

15. How fast do nerve impulses travel through the body?

- A. Up to 120 m/s
- B. Up to 50 m/s
- C. Up to 10 m/s
- D. Up to 1 m/s

MY SCORE: Round 1: ____/10 Round 2: ____/10 Round 3: ____/10
Round 4: ____/10 **TOTAL: ____/45**

CHAPTER CLOSE *Your body is running millions of simultaneous processes right now without any conscious effort. The complexity that keeps you alive every second makes the most sophisticated computer look primitive.*

CHAPTER 2 — ANSWER KEY

Round 2 — True or False

1. The human body replaces most of its cells within seven to ten... → **TRUE**
2. The human eye can detect a single photon of light.... → **TRUE**
3. Stomach acid can dissolve razor blades.... → **TRUE**
4. Humans emit visible light detectable by the naked eye.... → **FALSE**
5. The human brain generates approximately 20 watts of electric... → **TRUE**
6. Humans can distinguish approximately 10,000 different smells... → **FALSE**
7. Blood vessels in the human body would circle the Earth rough... → **TRUE**
8. The cornea gets oxygen from blood like all other body tissue... → **FALSE**
9. Goosebumps are a remnant from when humans had more body hair... → **TRUE**
10. The liver can regenerate from as little as 25% of its tissue... → **TRUE**

Round 3 — Could You Have Guessed?

1. How many new cells does your body produce per second? → **C. 25 million**
2. What is the approximate pH of stomach acid? → **B. 1–2**
3. How much electrical power does the human brain generate → **B. 20 watts**
4. How many smells can the human nose detect? → **D. One trillion**
5. How long are human blood vessels if laid end to end? → **C. 100,000 km**
6. How often does the stomach replace its lining? → **B. Every 3–4 days**
7. Which is the only tissue with no blood vessels that get → **C. Cornea**
8. What percentage of its tissue can the liver regenerate → **B. 25%**
9. What were goosebumps originally designed to do? → **B. Trap warmth and look bigger**
10. How many chromosomes do humans have? → **C. 46**

Round 4 — Quick Fire

1. What is the largest organ in the human body? → **Skin**
2. What is the medical term for the kneecap? → **Patella**
3. Which blood type is the universal donor? → **O negative**
4. How many bones are in the adult human body? → **206**
5. What connects muscle to bone? → **A tendon**
6. Which organ produces insulin? → **The pancreas**
7. What is the outer layer of skin called? → **The epidermis**
8. How many chambers does the heart have? → **Four**
9. What is the hardest substance in the human body? → **Tooth enamel**
10. How long does a red blood cell live approximately? → **About 120 days**

Round 5 — Stump Your Friends!

1. How many muscles does the face use to produce a smile (→ **C. 17**

2. What percentage of the human genome is shared with a ba → **D. 60%**
3. The human body has more bacterial cells than human cell → **D. They're roughly equal with slight bacterial majority**
4. How long would it take to fall asleep if you have sleep → **B. Under 5 minutes**
5. The surface area of human lungs, if spread flat, would → **B. Same as a tennis court**
6. Which part of the body has the most nerve endings per s → **D. Cornea**
7. How many times does the heart beat in an average lifeti → **C. 2.5 billion**
8. The human small intestine is approximately how long? → **C. 6–7 metres**
9. What percentage of the human brain is water? → **C. 73%**
10. Which chemical makes chillies hot? → **A. Capsaicin**
11. A human sneeze travels at approximately what speed? → **C. 160 mph**
12. The total length of nerves in the human body is approxi → **C. 75 km**
13. How many taste buds does the average adult have? → **C. 10,000**
14. What is the only muscle that never tires? → **C. Heart**
15. How fast do nerve impulses travel through the body? → **A. Up to 120 m/s**

CHAPTER 03 • UNBELIEVABLE BUT TRUE TRIVIA

Space & The Cosmos

Space does not care about your sense of scale. Nothing you have been told has prepared you for what it actually contains.

ROUND 1 — FACT BOMBS

Read these 10 astonishing facts carefully. Your next rounds will test whether they landed.

FACT #1

There are more stars in the observable universe than grains of sand on all of Earth's beaches combined — approximately 10^{24} stars.

★ *Every grain of sand represents a star. Multiply that by every beach on Earth.*

FACT #2

A day on Venus (one rotation) is longer than a year on Venus (one orbit around the Sun). Venus takes 243 Earth days to rotate but only 225 to orbit.

★ *The day outlasts the year.*

FACT #3

The footprints left by Apollo astronauts on the Moon will remain for approximately 100 million years — there is no wind or water to erode them.

★ *Those footprints are among the most permanent marks humans have ever made.*

FACT #4

Neutron stars are so dense that a single teaspoon of their material would weigh approximately one billion tonnes on Earth.

★ *A sugar-spoon sized object that would sink through the planet.*

FACT #5

If you removed all the empty space from atoms in every human on Earth, all of humanity would fit in a sugar cube.

★ *We are almost entirely nothing.*

FACT #6

The Voyager 1 spacecraft, launched in 1977, is the most distant human-made object. It entered interstellar space in 2012 and is still transmitting data to Earth.

★ *A 1970s machine, still working, 23 billion km away.*

FACT #7

Sound cannot travel through space because space is a near-perfect vacuum. The explosions shown in space films are physically impossible.

★ *The universe is completely silent.*

FACT #8

One million Earths could fit inside the Sun. But the Sun is considered an average-sized star — some stars are so large a billion Suns could fit inside them.

★ *Scale breaks down completely.*

FACT #9

Time passes faster at altitude. A clock on a mountain runs slightly faster than one at sea level due to gravitational time dilation — as proved by atomic clocks on aircraft.

★ *The higher you are, the faster time passes for you.*

FACT #10

Saturn would float on water. It is the only planet in the solar system with an average density less than water (0.687 g/cm³).

★ *The ringed giant is a cosmic rubber duck.*

ROUND 2**True or False** (10 statements based on the Fact Bombs • 1 pt each)

Mark each TRUE or FALSE — all answers relate to the facts you just read.

1. There are more stars in the observable universe than grains of sand on all Earth's beaches.

TRUE / FALSE

2. A day on Venus is shorter than a year on Venus.

TRUE / FALSE

3. Apollo footprints will remain on the Moon for approximately 100 million years.

TRUE / FALSE

4. A teaspoon of neutron star material would weigh one billion tonnes.

TRUE / FALSE

5. All of humanity could fit in a sugar cube if empty atomic space were removed.

TRUE / FALSE

6. Voyager 1 was launched in the 1990s.

TRUE / FALSE

7. Sound travels slowly through space.

TRUE / FALSE

8. The Sun is one of the largest stars known to exist.

TRUE / FALSE

9. Clocks at higher altitude run slightly faster due to gravity.

TRUE / FALSE

10. Saturn could float on water.

TRUE / FALSE

ROUND 3**Could You Have Guessed?** (10 multiple choice questions • 1 pt each)

Four options — only one is correct.

1. **How long does one rotation (day) take on Venus?**

- A. 100 Earth days
- B. 180 Earth days

- C. 243 Earth days
 - D. 365 Earth days
- 2. How many Earths could fit inside the Sun?**
- A. 100,000
 - B. 500,000
 - C. One million
 - D. Ten million
- 3. When did Voyager 1 enter interstellar space?**
- A. 1990
 - B. 2000
 - C. 2006
 - D. 2012
- 4. Why can't sound travel through space?**
- A. It travels too fast
 - B. Space is a near-vacuum
 - C. Temperature is too extreme
 - D. Gravity absorbs it
- 5. Saturn's density compared to water is:**
- A. Twice as dense
 - B. Same density
 - C. Less dense (floats)
 - D. Three times as dense
- 6. Gravitational time dilation means clocks at altitude run:**
- A. Slower
 - B. Faster
 - C. The same
 - D. Backwards
- 7. What is the approximate distance of Voyager 1 from Earth?**
- A. 2 billion km
 - B. 10 billion km
 - C. 23 billion km
 - D. 100 billion km
- 8. Approximately how many stars are in the observable universe?**
- A. 10^{12}
 - B. 10^{18}

C. 10^{24}

D. 10^{30}

9. Why will Apollo footprints last 100 million years?

A. The Moon's rock is very hard

B. No wind or water to erode them

C. They were sealed chemically

D. The Moon is frozen

10. What type of star is so large that a billion Suns could fit inside?

A. Red dwarf

B. White dwarf

C. Hypergiant

D. Pulsar

ROUND 4**Quick Fire (10 short-answer questions · 1 pt each)**

No options. Write your answer from memory.

- 1.** Who was the first human to walk on the Moon?

Answer:

- 2.** What is the closest star to Earth after the Sun?

Answer:

- 3.** How long does light from the Sun take to reach Earth?

Answer:

- 4.** What is a light-year a measure of?

Answer:

- 5.** Which planet is known as the Red Planet?

Answer:

- 6.** What was the name of the first artificial satellite?

Answer:

- 7.** How old is the universe approximately?

Answer:

- 8.** What is the term for a star exploding?

Answer:

- 9.** What causes a solar eclipse?

Answer:

- 10.** Which planet has the Great Red Spot?

Answer:

ROUND 5**Stump Your Friends! (15 harder questions · 1 pt each)**

The round that separates the curious from the truly knowledgeable. No mercy.

1. If the Sun were the size of a basketball, Earth would be the size of:

- A. A golf ball
- B. A pea
- C. A grain of sand
- D. A marble

2. How far away is the nearest galaxy to the Milky Way?

- A. 200,000 light-years
- B. 2.5 million light-years
- C. 25 million light-years
- D. 1 billion light-years

3. What is the approximate speed of light?

- A. 30,000 km/s
- B. 300,000 km/s
- C. 3,000,000 km/s
- D. 30 km/s

4. A black hole from which even light cannot escape is defined by its:

- A. Singularity
- B. Photon sphere
- C. Event horizon
- D. Schwarzschild radius

5. What is the temperature at the surface of the Sun?

- A. 1,000°C
- B. 5,500°C
- C. 15,000°C
- D. 1,000,000°C

6. In what year did the first humans land on the Moon?

- A. 1965
- B. 1967
- C. 1969
- D. 1972

7. What is the Milky Way's estimated diameter?

- A. 10,000 light-years
- B. 100,000 light-years
- C. 1 million light-years

- D. 10 million light-years
- 8. Which planet spins on its side (axial tilt $\sim 98^\circ$)?**
- A. Saturn
 - B. Neptune
 - C. Uranus
 - D. Jupiter
- 9. What did the James Webb Space Telescope launch in?**
- A. 2018
 - B. 2020
 - C. 2021
 - D. 2023
- 10. Pluto was reclassified as a dwarf planet in what year?**
- A. 2000
 - B. 2003
 - C. 2006
 - D. 2009
- 11. What is a pulsar?**
- A. A dying star
 - B. A rapidly rotating neutron star
 - C. A type of black hole
 - D. A young galaxy
- 12. The Sun will exhaust its hydrogen fuel in approximately:**
- A. 500 million years
 - B. 2 billion years
 - C. 5 billion years
 - D. 50 billion years
- 13. What is the name of the point of infinite density inside a black hole?**
- A. Event horizon
 - B. Photon sphere
 - C. Singularity
 - D. Quantum core
- 14. Mars has how many moons?**
- A. None
 - B. One
 - C. Two
 - D. Four

15. What is the hottest planet in our solar system?

- A. Mercury
- B. Mars
- C. Jupiter
- D. Venus

MY SCORE: Round 1: ____/10 Round 2: ____/10 Round 3: ____/10
Round 4: ____/15 **TOTAL: ____/45**

CHAPTER CLOSE *The universe is so large and so old that our entire human civilisation — every war, every invention, every life ever lived — would not register as a blip in the cosmic timeline. That's either terrifying or extraordinarily liberating, depending on how you look at it.*

CHAPTER 3 — ANSWER KEY

Round 2 — True or False

1. There are more stars in the observable universe than grains ... → **TRUE**
2. A day on Venus is shorter than a year on Venus.... → **FALSE**
3. Apollo footprints will remain on the Moon for approximately ... → **TRUE**
4. A teaspoon of neutron star material would weigh one billion ... → **TRUE**
5. All of humanity could fit in a sugar cube if empty atomic sp... → **TRUE**
6. Voyager 1 was launched in the 1990s.... → **FALSE**
7. Sound travels slowly through space.... → **FALSE**
8. The Sun is one of the largest stars known to exist.... → **FALSE**
9. Clocks at higher altitude run slightly faster due to gravity... → **TRUE**
10. Saturn could float on water.... → **TRUE**

Round 3 — Could You Have Guessed?

1. How long does one rotation (day) take on Venus? → **C. 243 Earth days**
2. How many Earths could fit inside the Sun? → **C. One million**
3. When did Voyager 1 enter interstellar space? → **D. 2012**
4. Why can't sound travel through space? → **B. Space is a near-vacuum**
5. Saturn's density compared to water is: → **C. Less dense (floats)**
6. Gravitational time dilation means clocks at altitude ru → **B. Faster**
7. What is the approximate distance of Voyager 1 from Earth → **C. 23 billion km**
8. Approximately how many stars are in the observable univ → **C. 10^{24}**
9. Why will Apollo footprints last 100 million years? → **B. No wind or water to erode them**
10. What type of star is so large that a billion Suns could → **C. Hypergiant**

Round 4 — Quick Fire

1. Who was the first human to walk on the Moon? → **Neil Armstrong**
2. What is the closest star to Earth after the Sun? → **Proxima Centauri**
3. How long does light from the Sun take to reach Earth? → **About 8 minutes**
4. What is a light-year a measure of? → **Distance (not time)**
5. Which planet is known as the Red Planet? → **Mars**
6. What was the name of the first artificial satellite? → **Sputnik**
7. How old is the universe approximately? → **13.8 billion years**
8. What is the term for a star exploding? → **A supernova**
9. What causes a solar eclipse? → **The Moon passes between Earth and the Sun**
10. Which planet has the Great Red Spot? → **Jupiter**

Round 5 — Stump Your Friends!

1. If the Sun were the size of a basketball, Earth would b → **B. A pea**
2. How far away is the nearest galaxy to the Milky Way? → **B. 2.5 million light-years**
3. What is the approximate speed of light? → **B. 300,000 km/s**
4. A black hole from which even light cannot escape is def → **C. Event horizon**
5. What is the temperature at the surface of the Sun? → **B. 5,500°C**
6. In what year did the first humans land on the Moon? → **C. 1969**
7. What is the Milky Way's estimated diameter? → **B. 100,000 light-years**
8. Which planet spins on its side (axial tilt ~98°)? → **C. Uranus**
9. What did the James Webb Space Telescope launch in? → **C. 2021**
10. Pluto was reclassified as a dwarf planet in what year? → **C. 2006**
11. What is a pulsar? → **B. A rapidly rotating neutron star**
12. The Sun will exhaust its hydrogen fuel in approximately → **C. 5 billion years**
13. What is the name of the point of infinite density insid → **C. Singularity**
14. Mars has how many moons? → **C. Two**
15. What is the hottest planet in our solar system? → **D. Venus**

CHAPTER 04 • UNBELIEVABLE BUT TRUE TRIVIA

History's Greatest Surprises

History is not what you were taught in school. The truth is far stranger — and far more human.

ROUND 1 — FACT BOMBS

Read these 10 astonishing facts carefully. Your next rounds will test whether they landed.

FACT #1

Cleopatra lived closer in time to the Moon landing than to the construction of the Great Pyramid of Giza. The pyramids are ancient even by her standards.

★ *Cleopatra is closer to us than to the pyramids.*

FACT #2

Oxford University is older than the Aztec Empire. Teaching began at Oxford around 1096 AD; the Aztec Empire was founded in 1428 AD.

★ *Europe's oldest university predates an entire New World civilisation.*

FACT #3

Napoleon was not short. He stood approximately 5 feet 6 inches — average for his era. The myth arose from British propaganda and a confusion between French and English inches.

★ *An entire stereotype built on a unit conversion error.*

FACT #4

The Great Wall of China is not visible from space with the naked eye. This has been confirmed by multiple astronauts, including Chinese astronaut Yang Liwei.

★ *One of history's most repeated "facts" — completely wrong.*

FACT #5

Viking helmets did not have horns. The horned helmet image came from 19th-century theatrical costumes, not archaeological evidence. Real Viking helmets were simple iron bowls.

★ *Hollywood invented an entire civilisation's costume.*

FACT #6

The shortest war in history was between Britain and Zanzibar in 1896. It lasted between 38 and 45 minutes.

★ *A war that ended before most meetings begin.*

FACT #7

During World War II, India contributed the largest volunteer army in history — over 2.5 million men — without conscription.

★ *A contribution largely absent from Western history books.*

FACT #8

Ancient Egyptians shaved their eyebrows off to mourn the death of a cat. Cats were sacred animals connected to the goddess Bastet.

★ *The ancient world's most extreme expression of grief.*

FACT #9

Abraham Lincoln was a licensed bartender before becoming President, and was also an accomplished wrestler — inducted into the Wrestling Hall of Fame in 1992.

★ *The most underrated presidential CV in history.*

FACT #10

The Library of Alexandria was not destroyed in a single catastrophic fire. It declined gradually over centuries through neglect, budget cuts, and multiple small incidents.

★ *History's most famous "burning" was actually a slow fade.*

ROUND 2**True or False (10 statements based on the Fact Bombs • 1 pt each)**

Mark each TRUE or FALSE — all answers relate to the facts you just read.

- 1.** Cleopatra lived closer in time to the Moon landing than to the Great Pyramid's construction.

TRUE / FALSE

- 2.** Oxford University was founded after the Aztec Empire.

TRUE / FALSE

- 3.** Napoleon was significantly below average height for his era.

TRUE / FALSE

- 4.** The Great Wall of China is visible from space with the naked eye.

TRUE / FALSE

- 5.** Archaeological evidence confirms Vikings wore horned helmets.

TRUE / FALSE

- 6.** The shortest war in history lasted under an hour.

TRUE / FALSE

- 7.** India's World War II volunteer army was over 2.5 million strong.

TRUE / FALSE

- 8.** Ancient Egyptians shaved their eyebrows to mourn a cat's death.

TRUE / FALSE

- 9.** Abraham Lincoln was a licensed bartender and accomplished wrestler.

TRUE / FALSE

- 10.** The Library of Alexandria was destroyed in a single catastrophic fire.

TRUE / FALSE

ROUND 3**Could You Have Guessed? (10 multiple choice questions • 1 pt each)**

Four options — only one is correct.

- 1. How long did the shortest war in history last?**
 - A. 38–45 minutes
 - B. 3 hours
 - C. 6 hours
 - D. 1 day
- 2. Oxford University began teaching in approximately what year?**
 - A. 800 AD
 - B. 1096 AD
 - C. 1200 AD
 - D. 1400 AD
- 3. When was the Aztec Empire founded?**
 - A. 1100 AD
 - B. 1300 AD
 - C. 1428 AD
 - D. 1500 AD
- 4. Napoleon's actual height was approximately:**
 - A. 5 ft 2 in
 - B. 5 ft 4 in
 - C. 5 ft 6 in
 - D. 5 ft 8 in
- 5. Which countries fought the shortest war?**
 - A. France and Germany
 - B. Britain and Zanzibar
 - C. Spain and Morocco
 - D. Portugal and Ethiopia
- 6. Abraham Lincoln was inducted into which Hall of Fame?**
 - A. Boxing
 - B. Wrestling
 - C. Fencing
 - D. Archery
- 7. How many men volunteered from India for WWII?**
 - A. 500,000
 - B. 1 million
 - C. 2.5 million
 - D. 5 million
- 8. Which goddess were Egyptian cats connected to?**

- A. Isis
- B. Hathor
- C. Bastet
- D. Sekhmet

9. Who confirmed the Great Wall is not visible from space?

- A. Neil Armstrong
- B. Buzz Aldrin
- C. Yang Liwei
- D. Tim Peake

10. The horned Viking helmet image came from:

- A. Danish museums
- B. 19th-century theatrical costumes
- C. Medieval paintings
- D. Norwegian folklore

ROUND 4**Quick Fire (10 short-answer questions · 1 pt each)**

No options. Write your answer from memory.

- 1.** In which year did Julius Caesar cross the Rubicon?

Answer:

- 2.** Which ancient civilisation built Machu Picchu?

Answer:

- 3.** Who was the first Roman Emperor?

Answer:

- 4.** What event started World War I?

Answer:

- 5.** In what year did the Berlin Wall fall?

Answer:

- 6.** Which empire was the largest in history by land area?

Answer:

- 7.** Who wrote the Communist Manifesto?

Answer:

- 8.** What was the name of the ship that sank in 1912?

Answer:

- 9.** In which country did the French Revolution begin?

Answer:

- 10.** Who commanded the Allied forces on D-Day?

Answer:

ROUND 5**Stump Your Friends! (15 harder questions · 1 pt each)**

The round that separates the curious from the truly knowledgeable. No mercy.

- 1. How many years after the Great Pyramid's construction was Cleopatra born (approximately)?**
 - A. 500 years
 - B. 1,500 years
 - C. 2,500 years
 - D. 3,500 years
- 2. The Egyptian pyramids were built using which workforce according to modern archaeological evidence?**
 - A. Slaves
 - B. Prisoners of war
 - C. Paid skilled workers
 - D. Conscripted peasants
- 3. What was the population of the Roman Empire at its peak (approximately)?**
 - A. 10 million
 - B. 30 million
 - C. 70 million
 - D. 200 million
- 4. Which war lasted the longest?**
 - A. 100 Years War (116 years)
 - B. Punic Wars (118 years)
 - C. Reconquista (781 years)
 - D. Crusades (200 years)
- 5. In which year did slavery become illegal in the United States?**
 - A. 1776
 - B. 1820
 - C. 1863
 - D. 1865
- 6. The Silk Road connected China to which westernmost point?**
 - A. Egypt
 - B. Rome
 - C. Constantinople
 - D. Baghdad

7. How long did the Byzantine Empire (Eastern Roman Empire) last?

- A. 200 years
- B. 500 years
- C. 800 years
- D. 1,000 years

8. Who was the first European to reach India by sea?

- A. Christopher Columbus
- B. Vasco da Gama
- C. Ferdinand Magellan
- D. Bartolomeu Dias

9. In what year was the Magna Carta signed?

- A. 1066
- B. 1215
- C. 1348
- D. 1400

10. Which ancient civilisation invented the zero?

- A. Egyptian
- B. Greek
- C. Babylonian
- D. Indian (Gupta period)

11. The Black Death killed approximately what fraction of Europe's population?

- A. One tenth
- B. One quarter
- C. One third to one half
- D. Two thirds

12. Who was the last Pharaoh of ancient Egypt?

- A. Cleopatra VII
- B. Nefertiti
- C. Hatshepsut
- D. Ramesses II

13. What did the Romans use garum for?

- A. Medicine
- B. A fermented fish sauce condiment
- C. Religious ceremonies
- D. Preserving leather

14. How long did the Hundred Years War actually last?

- A. 80 years
- B. 100 years
- C. 116 years
- D. 130 years

15. Which country was the first to give women the right to vote?

- A. UK
- B. USA
- C. New Zealand
- D. Sweden

MY SCORE: Round 1: ____ /10 Round 2: ____ /10 Round 3: ____ /10
Round 4: ____ /10 **TOTAL: ____/45**

CHAPTER CLOSE *Every historical "fact" you were told with confidence has an asterisk. The further back you look, the messier, stranger, and more human the story gets. History is not clean narrative — it's argument, accident, and survival.*

CHAPTER 4 — ANSWER KEY

Round 2 — True or False

1. Cleopatra lived closer in time to the Moon landing than to t... → **TRUE**
2. Oxford University was founded after the Aztec Empire.... → **FALSE**
3. Napoleon was significantly below average height for his era.... → **FALSE**
4. The Great Wall of China is visible from space with the naked... → **FALSE**
5. Archaeological evidence confirms Vikings wore horned helmets... → **FALSE**
6. The shortest war in history lasted under an hour.... → **TRUE**
7. India's World War II volunteer army was over 2.5 million str... → **TRUE**
8. Ancient Egyptians shaved their eyebrows to mourn a cat's dea... → **TRUE**
9. Abraham Lincoln was a licensed bartender and accomplished wr... → **TRUE**
10. The Library of Alexandria was destroyed in a single catastro... → **FALSE**

Round 3 — Could You Have Guessed?

1. How long did the shortest war in history last? → **A. 38–45 minutes**
2. Oxford University began teaching in approximately what → **B. 1096 AD**
3. When was the Aztec Empire founded? → **C. 1428 AD**
4. Napoleon's actual height was approximately: → **C. 5 ft 6 in**
5. Which countries fought the shortest war? → **B. Britain and Zanzibar**
6. Abraham Lincoln was inducted into which Hall of Fame? → **B. Wrestling**
7. How many men volunteered from India for WWII? → **C. 2.5 million**
8. Which goddess were Egyptian cats connected to? → **C. Bastet**
9. Who confirmed the Great Wall is not visible from space? → **C. Yang Liwei**
10. The horned Viking helmet image came from: → **B. 19th-century theatrical costumes**

Round 4 — Quick Fire

1. In which year did Julius Caesar cross the Rubicon? → **49 BC**
2. Which ancient civilisation built Machu Picchu? → **The Inca**
3. Who was the first Roman Emperor? → **Augustus**
4. What event started World War I? → **Assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand**
5. In what year did the Berlin Wall fall? → **1989**
6. Which empire was the largest in history by land area? → **The Mongol Empire (or British Empire depending on method)**
7. Who wrote the Communist Manifesto? → **Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels**
8. What was the name of the ship that sank in 1912? → **The Titanic (RMS Titanic)**
9. In which country did the French Revolution begin? → **France**
10. Who commanded the Allied forces on D-Day? → **Dwight D. Eisenhower**

Round 5 — Stump Your Friends!

1. How many years after the Great Pyramid's construction w → **C. 2,500 years**
2. The Egyptian pyramids were built using which workforce → **C. Paid skilled workers**
3. What was the population of the Roman Empire at its peak → **C. 70 million**
4. Which war lasted the longest? → **C. Reconquista (781 years)**
5. In which year did slavery become illegal in the United → **D. 1865**
6. The Silk Road connected China to which westernmost poin → **B. Rome**
7. How long did the Byzantine Empire (Eastern Roman Empire → **D. 1,000 years**
8. Who was the first European to reach India by sea? → **B. Vasco da Gama**
9. In what year was the Magna Carta signed? → **B. 1215**
10. Which ancient civilisation invented the zero? → **D. Indian (Gupta period)**
11. The Black Death killed approximately what fraction of E → **C. One third to one half**
12. Who was the last Pharaoh of ancient Egypt? → **A. Cleopatra VII**
13. What did the Romans use garum for? → **B. A fermented fish sauce condiment**
14. How long did the Hundred Years War actually last? → **C. 116 years**
15. Which country was the first to give women the right to → **C. New Zealand**

CHAPTER 05 • UNBELIEVABLE BUT TRUE TRIVIA

Science's Most Shocking Discoveries

Science has revealed that reality is nothing like it appears. The more we learn, the stranger everything becomes.

ROUND 1 — FACT BOMBS

Read these 10 astonishing facts carefully. Your next rounds will test whether they landed.

FACT #1

Quantum entanglement means two particles can be linked so that measuring one instantly affects the other — no matter if they're separated by the entire universe.

★ *Einstein called it "spooky action at a distance." Experiments have since proved him wrong.*

FACT #2

Hot water can freeze faster than cold water under certain conditions — a phenomenon called the Mpemba Effect. It was reported by a Tanzanian student in 1963 and is still not fully explained.

★ *Something that shouldn't work, demonstrably does.*

FACT #3

There is a species of jellyfish (*Turritopsis dohrnii*) that is biologically immortal. When it ages or is stressed, it reverts to its juvenile polyp stage and begins its lifecycle again.

★ *An animal that resets to zero and starts over.*

FACT #4

At the quantum level, particles exist in superposition — in multiple states simultaneously — until observed. The act of measurement changes the outcome.

★ *Reality is literally shaped by looking at it.*

FACT #5

The placebo effect is so powerful that fake surgeries — where patients are cut open and sewn back up without any procedure — sometimes produce the same outcomes as real operations.

★ *The mind heals the body by believing it has been healed.*

FACT #6

DNA is so tightly coiled that if you unravelled all the DNA from a single human cell and stretched it out, it would be approximately two metres long.

★ *Two metres of code crammed into something invisible.*

FACT #7

Antimatter exists — the opposite of matter — and annihilates on contact. The entire observable universe should, in theory, have equal matter and antimatter and cancel itself out. That it didn't is one of physics's greatest mysteries.

★ *We exist because of an asymmetry nobody can explain.*

FACT #8

Water has memory — under certain experimental conditions, water's hydrogen bonds can hold structural information for picoseconds. This is why ice crystals form in unique patterns.

★ *Each snowflake is genuinely, mathematically unique.*

FACT #9

A 2020 study found microplastics in human lungs, blood, and placentas. Humans now consume approximately a credit card's worth of plastic per week through food and water.

★ *We are eating our packaging.*

FACT #10

The total weight of all ants on Earth is estimated to equal — or exceed — the total weight of all humans. There are approximately 20 quadrillion ants alive right now.

★ *The planet belongs to insects, not us.*

ROUND 2**True or False (10 statements based on the Fact Bombs • 1 pt each)**

Mark each TRUE or FALSE — all answers relate to the facts you just read.

1. Quantum entanglement allows particles to instantly affect each other regardless of distance.

TRUE / FALSE

2. The Mpemba Effect describes hot water freezing faster than cold water.

TRUE / FALSE

3. *Turritopsis dohrnii* jellyfish can revert to their juvenile stage and are biologically immortal.

TRUE / FALSE

4. In quantum mechanics, observing a particle has no effect on its state.

TRUE / FALSE

5. Sham (fake) surgeries can sometimes produce the same outcomes as real operations.

TRUE / FALSE

6. Human DNA in a single cell, if unravelled, would be approximately 2 metres long.

TRUE / FALSE

7. The universe has perfectly equal amounts of matter and antimatter.

TRUE / FALSE

8. Every snowflake has a genuinely unique crystal structure.

TRUE / FALSE

9. Humans consume approximately a credit card's worth of plastic per week.

TRUE / FALSE

10. The total weight of all ants on Earth is less than one percent of all human weight.

TRUE / FALSE

ROUND 3

Could You Have Guessed? (10 multiple choice questions • 1 pt each)

Four options — only one is correct.

- 1. What did Einstein call quantum entanglement?**
 - A. "Absurd physics"
 - B. "Spooky action at a distance"
 - C. "The God phenomenon"
 - D. "Impossible mechanics"
- 2. Who reported the Mpemba Effect in 1963?**
 - A. A German physicist
 - B. A British chemist
 - C. A Tanzanian student
 - D. A Soviet scientist
- 3. How does *Turritopsis dohrnii* avoid death?**
 - A. It doesn't age
 - B. It clones itself
 - C. It reverts to juvenile polyp stage
 - D. It rebuilds DNA
- 4. Approximately how long is DNA from one human cell if unravelled?**
 - A. 10 cm
 - B. 50 cm
 - C. 2 metres
 - D. 10 metres
- 5. How many ants are estimated to be alive on Earth?**
 - A. 1 trillion
 - B. 1 quadrillion
 - C. 20 quadrillion
 - D. 1 sextillion
- 6. What does antimatter do when it contacts matter?**
 - A. Transforms it
 - B. Repels it
 - C. Annihilates both
 - D. Absorbs it
- 7. What is quantum superposition?**
 - A. Particles stacking on each other
 - B. Multiple states simultaneously before observation
 - C. Faster-than-light movement

D. Entanglement at distance

8. How much plastic does a human consume per week on average?

- A. A grain of rice worth**
- B. A teaspoon worth**
- C. A credit card worth**
- D. A bottle cap worth**

9. The placebo effect can even work in:

- A. Only mild conditions**
- B. Only mental illness**
- C. Fake surgeries**
- D. Only pain relief**

10. What is the unresolved mystery of antimatter?

- A. Why it's so rare**
- B. Why it's hotter**
- C. Why the universe has more matter than antimatter**
- D. Why it glows**

ROUND 4**Quick Fire (10 short-answer questions · 1 pt each)**

No options. Write your answer from memory.

- 1.** What does DNA stand for?

Answer:

- 2.** What is the speed of light in a vacuum?

Answer:

- 3.** Which scientist developed the theory of general relativity?

Answer:

- 4.** What particle has no electric charge?

Answer:

- 5.** What is the study of fungi called?

Answer:

- 6.** What is the most abundant element in the universe?

Answer:

- 7.** What force governs atomic nuclei?

Answer:

- 8.** What is absolute zero in Celsius?

Answer:

- 9.** What is the powerhouse of the cell?

Answer:

- 10.** Who proposed the heliocentric model of the solar system?

Answer:

ROUND 5**Stump Your Friends! (15 harder questions · 1 pt each)**

The round that separates the curious from the truly knowledgeable. No mercy.

- 1. Schrödinger's cat is a thought experiment illustrating which problem?**
 - A. Nuclear decay
 - B. Quantum superposition at macroscopic scale
 - C. Wave-particle duality
 - D. Antimatter creation
- 2. What percentage of the universe is dark matter and dark energy combined?**
 - A. 27%
 - B. 50%
 - C. 68%
 - D. 95%
- 3. The Higgs boson is sometimes called the "God particle." What does it do?**
 - A. Creates gravity
 - B. Gives particles mass
 - C. Binds atoms
 - D. Generates magnetism
- 4. Water is the only common substance that is less dense as a solid than a liquid. This is why:**
 - A. Ice melts slowly
 - B. Ice floats
 - C. Steam rises
 - D. Water conducts electricity
- 5. Which element has the highest melting point?**
 - A. Iron
 - B. Titanium
 - C. Tungsten
 - D. Carbon
- 6. What is CRISPR?**
 - A. A particle accelerator
 - B. A gene-editing technology
 - C. A quantum computer component
 - D. A type of dark matter
- 7. The double helix structure of DNA was published in which year?**

- A. 1943
 - B. 1953
 - C. 1963
 - D. 1973
- 8. Which force is responsible for radioactive decay?**
- A. Gravity
 - B. Electromagnetic
 - C. Strong nuclear
 - D. Weak nuclear
- 9. How many dimensions does string theory propose?**
- A. 4
 - B. 6
 - C. 10 or 11
 - D. 26
- 10. What is the half-life of Carbon-14?**
- A. 570 years
 - B. 1,200 years
 - C. 5,730 years
 - D. 57,000 years
- 11. Bell's theorem proves which aspect of quantum mechanics?**
- A. Light is a particle
 - B. Entanglement is real and non-local
 - C. Gravity curves space
 - D. Particles have definite positions
- 12. What is bioluminescence?**
- A. Heat energy visible as light
 - B. Light produced by chemical reactions in living organisms
 - C. Reflection of UV light
 - D. Electrical discharge through tissues
- 13. Which planet has the strongest magnetic field in the solar system?**
- A. Saturn
 - B. Earth
 - C. Uranus
 - D. Jupiter
- 14. What is the Doppler effect?**
- A. Light bending around gravity

- B. Change in wave frequency due to movement of source or observer
- C. Sound acceleration in solids
- D. Quantum particle spin

15. What does $E=mc^2$ state?

- A. Energy equals mass times the speed of light
- B. Energy equals mass times the speed of light squared
- C. Efficiency equals mass times compression
- D. Entropy equals matter times constant

MY SCORE: Round 1: ____ /10 Round 2: ____ /10 Round 3: ____ /10
Round 4: ____ /15 **TOTAL: ____/45**

CHAPTER CLOSE *Science's job is not to confirm what we expect — it's to demolish our certainties and replace them with something stranger and more accurate. Every major discovery in history arrived as a shock.*

CHAPTER 5 — ANSWER KEY

Round 2 — True or False

1. Quantum entanglement allows particles to instantly affect ea... → **TRUE**
2. The Mpemba Effect describes hot water freezing faster than c... → **TRUE**
3. Turritopsis dohrnii jellyfish can revert to their juvenile s... → **TRUE**
4. In quantum mechanics, observing a particle has no effect on ... → **FALSE**
5. Sham (fake) surgeries can sometimes produce the same outcome... → **TRUE**
6. Human DNA in a single cell, if unravelled, would be approxim... → **TRUE**
7. The universe has perfectly equal amounts of matter and antim... → **FALSE**
8. Every snowflake has a genuinely unique crystal structure.... → **TRUE**
9. Humans consume approximately a credit card's worth of plasti... → **TRUE**
10. The total weight of all ants on Earth is less than one perce... → **FALSE**

Round 3 — Could You Have Guessed?

1. What did Einstein call quantum entanglement? → **B. "Spooky action at a distance"**
2. Who reported the Mpemba Effect in 1963? → **C. A Tanzanian student**
3. How does Turritopsis dohrnii avoid death? → **C. It reverts to juvenile polyp stage**
4. Approximately how long is DNA from one human cell if un → **C. 2 metres**
5. How many ants are estimated to be alive on Earth? → **C. 20 quadrillion**
6. What does antimatter do when it contacts matter? → **C. Annihilates both**
7. What is quantum superposition? → **B. Multiple states simultaneously before observation**
8. How much plastic does a human consume per week on avera → **C. A credit card worth**
9. The placebo effect can even work in: → **C. Fake surgeries**
10. What is the unresolved mystery of antimatter? → **C. Why the universe has more matter than antimatter**

Round 4 — Quick Fire

1. What does DNA stand for? → **Deoxyribonucleic acid**
2. What is the speed of light in a vacuum? → **Approximately 300,000 km/s**
3. Which scientist developed the theory of general relativity? → **Albert Einstein**
4. What particle has no electric charge? → **Neutron**
5. What is the study of fungi called? → **Mycology**
6. What is the most abundant element in the universe? → **Hydrogen**
7. What force governs atomic nuclei? → **The strong nuclear force**
8. What is absolute zero in Celsius? → **-273.15°C**
9. What is the powerhouse of the cell? → **The mitochondria**
10. Who proposed the heliocentric model of the solar system? → **Copernicus**

Round 5 — Stump Your Friends!

1. Schrödinger's cat is a thought experiment illustrating → **B. Quantum superposition at macroscopic scale**
2. What percentage of the universe is dark matter and dark → **D. 95%**
3. The Higgs boson is sometimes called the "God particle." → **B. Gives particles mass**
4. Water is the only common substance that is less dense a → **B. Ice floats**
5. Which element has the highest melting point? → **C. Tungsten**
6. What is CRISPR? → **B. A gene-editing technology**
7. The double helix structure of DNA was published in whic → **B. 1953**
8. Which force is responsible for radioactive decay? → **D. Weak nuclear**
9. How many dimensions does string theory propose? → **C. 10 or 11**
10. What is the half-life of Carbon-14? → **C. 5,730 years**
11. Bell's theorem proves which aspect of quantum mechanics → **B. Entanglement is real and non-local**
12. What is bioluminescence? → **B. Light produced by chemical reactions in living organisms**
13. Which planet has the strongest magnetic field in the so → **D. Jupiter**
14. What is the Doppler effect? → **B. Change in wave frequency due to movement of source or observer**
15. What does $E=mc^2$ state? → **B. Energy equals mass times the speed of light squared**

CHAPTER 06 • UNBELIEVABLE BUT TRUE TRIVIA

Food & Drink — The Unbelievable Truth

Everything you eat has a story weirder than the ingredient list suggests.

ROUND 1 — FACT BOMBS

Read these 10 astonishing facts carefully. Your next rounds will test whether they landed.

FACT #1

Honey never spoils. Archaeologists have found 3,000-year-old honey in Egyptian tombs that was still perfectly edible.

★ *The perfect preservative is made by insects.*

FACT #2

Bananas are technically berries. Strawberries are not. In botanical terms, a berry must develop from a single flower's ovary — strawberries develop from a flower with multiple ovaries.

★ *The entire definition of "berry" has been wrong all along.*

FACT #3

Carrots were originally purple, not orange. Orange carrots were selectively bred in the 17th century in the Netherlands, reportedly to honour the Dutch Royal House of Orange.

★ *The vegetable was politically motivated.*

FACT #4

The world's most expensive coffee — Kopi Luwak — is made from beans that have been eaten and passed through the digestive system of a civet cat. It sells for up to \$600 per kilogram.

★ *The world's most exclusive coffee is literally cat excrement.*

FACT #5

Eating polar bear liver is fatal to humans. It contains such extreme concentrations of Vitamin A that a single liver would be lethal.

★ *Too many vitamins can kill you.*

FACT #6

Saffron is worth more by weight than gold. It takes approximately 150,000 crocus flowers to produce one kilogram of saffron, all hand-harvested.

★ *The most labour-intensive spice on the planet.*

FACT #7

Apples, pears, cherries, and strawberries all belong to the rose family (Rosaceae). The next time you eat an apple, you're eating a relative of a rose.

★ *Flowers and fruit are closer than you thought.*

FACT #8

Vanilla is the second most expensive spice in the world after saffron. Natural vanilla comes from an orchid and must be hand-pollinated in countries outside Mexico, where its native bee no longer lives.

★ *Every vanilla bean was touched by human hands.*

FACT #9

The Maillard reaction — not caramelisation — is responsible for the delicious browning when you cook meat, toast bread, or sear vegetables. It involves a reaction between amino acids and sugars.

★ *The best flavours in cooking come from chemistry.*

FACT #10

Decaffeinated coffee still contains caffeine. The decaffeination process removes 97%+ of caffeine — not all of it. A "decaf" espresso contains 15–30mg of caffeine.

★ *The only truly caffeine-free coffee is the one you don't drink.*

ROUND 2**True or False (10 statements based on the Fact Bombs • 1 pt each)**

Mark each TRUE or FALSE — all answers relate to the facts you just read.

1. Honey is archaeologically confirmed to never spoil.
TRUE / FALSE
2. Strawberries are botanically classified as berries.
TRUE / FALSE
3. Carrots were originally purple before selective breeding.
TRUE / FALSE
4. Kopi Luwak coffee is made from beans processed through a civet cat's digestive system.
TRUE / FALSE
5. Eating polar bear liver is harmless to humans.
TRUE / FALSE
6. Saffron is more valuable by weight than gold.
TRUE / FALSE
7. Apples belong to the rose family.
TRUE / FALSE
8. Natural vanilla comes from a lily plant.
TRUE / FALSE
9. The Maillard reaction is the same as caramelisation.
TRUE / FALSE
10. Decaffeinated coffee contains zero caffeine.
TRUE / FALSE

ROUND 3**Could You Have Guessed? (10 multiple choice questions • 1 pt each)**

Four options — only one is correct.

1. How old was the honey found in Egyptian tombs?
 - A. 500 years
 - B. 1,000 years
 - C. 3,000 years
 - D. 5,000 years

- 2. Why are strawberries not botanical berries?**
 - A. They have seeds on the outside
 - B. They develop from multiple ovaries
 - C. They're too small
 - D. They lack a pip
- 3. Saffron comes from which part of the crocus flower?**
 - A. The petals
 - B. The roots
 - C. The stigma
 - D. The pollen
- 4. Polar bear liver is dangerous due to excess:**
 - A. Vitamin A
 - B. Vitamin D
 - C. Vitamin K
 - D. Iron
- 5. The Maillard reaction involves:**
 - A. Sugar melting
 - B. Amino acids reacting with sugars
 - C. Fats oxidising
 - D. Water evaporating
- 6. What percentage of caffeine does decaffeination remove?**
 - A. 50%
 - B. 75%
 - C. 90%
 - D. 97%+
- 7. How many crocus flowers produce 1kg of saffron?**
 - A. 10,000
 - B. 50,000
 - C. 150,000
 - D. 500,000
- 8. Orange carrots were bred in which country?**
 - A. England
 - B. France
 - C. Germany
 - D. Netherlands
- 9. Kopi Luwak can sell for up to how much per kilogram?**

- A. \$100
- B. \$200
- C. \$600
- D. \$2,000

10. The vanilla orchid outside Mexico must be:

- A. Grown indoors
- B. Hand-pollinated
- C. Harvested at night
- D. Dried for two years

ROUND 4**Quick Fire (10 short-answer questions · 1 pt each)**

No options. Write your answer from memory.

- 1.** Which country produces the most coffee?

Answer:

- 2.** What grain is used to make traditional sake?

Answer:

- 3.** What does "al dente" mean in cooking?

Answer:

- 4.** Which spice comes from tree bark?

Answer:

- 5.** What is the main ingredient in guacamole?

Answer:

- 6.** Which country invented sushi?

Answer:

- 7.** What makes chillies hot?

Answer:

- 8.** From which country does Gouda cheese come?

Answer:

- 9.** What is miso made from?

Answer:

- 10.** What are the five French mother sauces?

Answer:

ROUND 5**Stump Your Friends! (15 harder questions · 1 pt each)**

The round that separates the curious from the truly knowledgeable. No mercy.

- 1. What is umami?**
 - A. A Japanese seasoning
 - B. The fifth basic taste (savoury)
 - C. A type of fermentation
 - D. A cooking technique
- 2. Tempeh is made from fermented:**
 - A. Rice
 - B. Chickpeas
 - C. Soybeans
 - D. Lentils
- 3. Which vitamin is synthesised by skin in sunlight?**
 - A. Vitamin A
 - B. Vitamin B12
 - C. Vitamin C
 - D. Vitamin D
- 4. The tomato was considered poisonous in Europe until approximately:**
 - A. 1500s
 - B. 1600s
 - C. 1700s
 - D. 1800s
- 5. Wasabi and horseradish belong to the same family. That family is:**
 - A. Apiaceae
 - B. Brassicaceae
 - C. Lamiaceae
 - D. Solanaceae
- 6. What is the Scoville scale used to measure?**
 - A. Wine acidity
 - B. Chilli heat
 - C. Coffee strength
 - D. Cheese intensity
- 7. Champagne legally must come from the Champagne region of which country?**
 - A. Italy
 - B. Spain

- C. Belgium
 - D. France
- 8. Which nut is used to make traditional marzipan?**
- A. Walnut
 - B. Cashew
 - C. Hazelnut
 - D. Almond
- 9. What causes bread to rise?**
- A. Baking powder only
 - B. Yeast producing CO₂
 - C. Steam from water
 - D. Gluten expansion
- 10. What cooking method uses temperature-controlled water baths?**
- A. Confit
 - B. Braise
 - C. Sous vide
 - D. Bain-marie
- 11. Peanuts are technically classified as:**
- A. Nuts
 - B. Seeds
 - C. Legumes
 - D. Tubers
- 12. What is the active compound in coffee that causes alertness?**
- A. Theobromine
 - B. Caffeine
 - C. Tannin
 - D. Chlorogenic acid
- 13. Which country consumes the most chocolate per capita?**
- A. Belgium
 - B. UK
 - C. Germany
 - D. Switzerland
- 14. What is the correct term for a baby vegetable grown extra small?**
- A. Micro

- B. Nano
- C. Petit
- D. Sprout

15. Which fermented drink is made from mare's milk?

- A. Kvass
- B. Tepache
- C. Kumiss
- D. Lassi

MY SCORE: Round 1: ____ /10 Round 2: ____ /10 Round 3: ____ /10
Round 4: ____ /15 TOTAL: ____ /45

CHAPTER CLOSE *Food is chemistry, culture, and history all at once. The ingredients in your kitchen have stories spanning centuries, continents, and civilisations. Every meal is a quietly remarkable event.*

CHAPTER 6 — ANSWER KEY

Round 2 — True or False

1. Honey is archaeologically confirmed to never spoil.... → **TRUE**
2. Strawberries are botanically classified as berries.... → **FALSE**
3. Carrots were originally purple before selective breeding.... → **TRUE**
4. Kopi Luwak coffee is made from beans processed through a civ... → **TRUE**
5. Eating polar bear liver is harmless to humans.... → **FALSE**
6. Saffron is more valuable by weight than gold.... → **TRUE**
7. Apples belong to the rose family.... → **TRUE**
8. Natural vanilla comes from a lily plant.... → **FALSE**
9. The Maillard reaction is the same as caramelisation.... → **FALSE**
10. Decaffeinated coffee contains zero caffeine.... → **FALSE**

Round 3 — Could You Have Guessed?

1. How old was the honey found in Egyptian tombs? → **C. 3,000 years**
2. Why are strawberries not botanical berries? → **B. They develop from multiple ovaries**
3. Saffron comes from which part of the crocus flower? → **C. The stigma**
4. Polar bear liver is dangerous due to excess: → **A. Vitamin A**
5. The Maillard reaction involves: → **B. Amino acids reacting with sugars**
6. What percentage of caffeine does decaffeination remove? → **D. 97%+**
7. How many crocus flowers produce 1kg of saffron? → **C. 150,000**
8. Orange carrots were bred in which country? → **D. Netherlands**
9. Kopi Luwak can sell for up to how much per kilogram? → **C. \$600**
10. The vanilla orchid outside Mexico must be: → **B. Hand-pollinated**

Round 4 — Quick Fire

1. Which country produces the most coffee? → **Brazil**
2. What grain is used to make traditional sake? → **Rice**
3. What does "al dente" mean in cooking? → **"To the tooth" — slightly firm**
4. Which spice comes from tree bark? → **Cinnamon**
5. What is the main ingredient in guacamole? → **Avocado**
6. Which country invented sushi? → **Japan**
7. What makes chillies hot? → **Capsaicin**
8. From which country does Gouda cheese come? → **The Netherlands**
9. What is miso made from? → **Fermented soybeans**
10. What are the five French mother sauces? → **Béchamel, Velouté, Espagnole, Hollandaise, Sauce Tomat**

Round 5 — Stump Your Friends!

1. What is umami? → **B. The fifth basic taste (savory)**

2. Tempeh is made from fermented: → **C. Soybeans**
3. Which vitamin is synthesised by skin in sunlight? → **D. Vitamin D**
4. The tomato was considered poisonous in Europe until app → **C. 1700s**
5. Wasabi and horseradish belong to the same family. That → **B. Brassicaceae**
6. What is the Scoville scale used to measure? → **B. Chilli heat**
7. Champagne legally must come from the Champagne region o → **D. France**
8. Which nut is used to make traditional marzipan? → **D. Almond**
9. What causes bread to rise? → **B. Yeast producing CO₂**
10. What cooking method uses temperature-controlled water b → **C. Sous vide**
11. Peanuts are technically classified as: → **C. Legumes**
12. What is the active compound in coffee that causes alert → **B. Caffeine**
13. Which country consumes the most chocolate per capita? → **D. Switzerland**
14. What is the correct term for a baby vegetable grown ext → **A. Micro**
15. Which fermented drink is made from mare's milk? → **C. Kumiss**

CHAPTER 07 • UNBELIEVABLE BUT TRUE TRIVIA

Language, Words & Communication

Language shapes reality. And the reality of language is far stranger than you've been led to believe.

ROUND 1 — FACT BOMBS

Read these 10 astonishing facts carefully. Your next rounds will test whether they landed.

FACT #1

The English language gains approximately 1,000 new words every year. The Oxford English Dictionary adds new entries constantly — "selfie," "emoji," and "ghosting" are all official words.

★ *Language evolves faster than most laws change.*

FACT #2

Shakespeare invented over 1,700 words still used in English — including "bedroom," "lonely," "generous," "obscene," and "eyeball."

★ *A single playwright reshaped your vocabulary.*

FACT #3

The Hawaiian language originally had only 13 letters in its alphabet. The full current alphabet has 13 as well — five vowels and eight consonants.

★ *One of the smallest alphabets of any world language.*

FACT #4

"Pneumonoultramicroscopicsilicovolcanoconiosis" is the longest word in the English language — a lung disease caused by inhaling very fine silica dust.

★ *The longest word is a medical diagnosis, not a joke.*

FACT #5

Mandarin Chinese has no alphabet. It uses approximately 50,000 characters, of which an educated person typically knows 8,000–10,000. Literacy requires years of character memorisation.

★ *Reading a Chinese newspaper requires memorising 3,000 characters.*

FACT #6

The language with the most words is English — with over 170,000 words in current use and 47,000 obsolete words, according to the Oxford English Dictionary.

★ *Yet most people use around 20,000–35,000 words actively.*

FACT #7

Sign language is not universal. There are over 300 different sign languages worldwide, each with its own grammar, idioms, and regional dialects.

★ *British Sign Language and American Sign Language are mutually unintelligible.*

FACT #8

The word "salary" comes from the Latin "salarium" — payment made to Roman soldiers in salt, which was extremely valuable in the ancient world.

★ *You are paid in the historical equivalent of seasoning.*

FACT #9

Welsh has no word for "blue" and "green" in the traditional sense — both colours were historically covered by the word "glas," which now refers to blue-green shades.

★ *Colour vocabulary shapes how cultures perceive colour.*

FACT #10

"E" is the most commonly used letter in English, appearing in approximately 11% of all text. "Z" appears less than 0.1% of the time.

★ *Remove all the E's from this book and it becomes nearly unreadable.*

ROUND 2**True or False (10 statements based on the Fact Bombs • 1 pt each)**

Mark each TRUE or FALSE — all answers relate to the facts you just read.

1. English gains approximately 1,000 new words every year.
TRUE / FALSE
2. Shakespeare invented over 1,700 words still in use.
TRUE / FALSE
3. The Hawaiian alphabet has 26 letters.
TRUE / FALSE
4. The longest English word is a type of medical condition.
TRUE / FALSE
5. Mandarin Chinese has approximately 50,000 characters.
TRUE / FALSE
6. English has fewer words than French.
TRUE / FALSE
7. All sign languages worldwide use the same grammar and signs.
TRUE / FALSE
8. The word "salary" derives from Roman payments made in salt.
TRUE / FALSE
9. Welsh traditionally had separate words for blue and green.
TRUE / FALSE
10. "E" is the most common letter in English.
TRUE / FALSE

ROUND 3**Could You Have Guessed? (10 multiple choice questions • 1 pt each)**

Four options — only one is correct.

1. How many letters are in the Hawaiian alphabet?
 - A. 8
 - B. 13
 - C. 18
 - D. 26
2. How many words does English have in current use?

- A. 50,000
 - B. 100,000
 - C. 170,000
 - D. 500,000
- 3. How many words did Shakespeare invent?**
- A. Over 500
 - B. Over 1,000
 - C. Over 1,700
 - D. Over 3,000
- 4. What does "salary" literally derive from?**
- A. Gold
 - B. Silver
 - C. Salt
 - D. Silk
- 5. How many sign languages exist worldwide?**
- A. About 10
 - B. About 50
 - C. Over 100
 - D. Over 300
- 6. How many Mandarin characters does an educated person typically know?**
- A. 3,000
 - B. 8,000–10,000
 - C. 20,000
 - D. 50,000
- 7. The Welsh word "glas" covers which colours?**
- A. Red and orange
 - B. Blue and green
 - C. Yellow and white
 - D. Purple and grey
- 8. "E" appears in approximately what percentage of English text?**
- A. 4%
 - B. 7%
 - C. 11%
 - D. 18%
- 9. Which playwright is credited with inventing the word "eyeball"?**

- A. Marlowe
- B. Jonson
- C. Shakespeare
- D. Milton

10. How many words does the average person actively use?

- A. 5,000–10,000
- B. 20,000–35,000
- C. 50,000–70,000
- D. 100,000+

ROUND 4**Quick Fire (10 short-answer questions · 1 pt each)**

No options. Write your answer from memory.

- 1.** What language has the most native speakers?

Answer:

- 2.** What is the study of the origin of words called?

Answer:

- 3.** What is the term for a word that sounds like what it describes?

Answer:

- 4.** What literary device starts multiple words with the same consonant?

Answer:

- 5.** In how many languages has the Bible been translated?

Answer:

- 6.** What is a palindrome?

Answer:

- 7.** What does the word "philosophy" mean in Greek?

Answer:

- 8.** What is the world's most translated document?

Answer:

- 9.** What is the longest word in common everyday use in English?

Answer:

- 10.** What is an oxymoron?

Answer:

ROUND 5**Stump Your Friends! (15 harder questions · 1 pt each)**

The round that separates the curious from the truly knowledgeable. No mercy.

- 1. How many languages are spoken worldwide?**
 - A. About 1,000
 - B. About 3,000
 - C. About 7,000
 - D. About 20,000
- 2. What percentage of the world's languages are spoken by fewer than 1,000 people?**
 - A. 10%
 - B. 25%
 - C. 40%
 - D. 60%
- 3. The Piraha language of the Amazon has no words for:**
 - A. Colour
 - B. Numbers (has limited counting)
 - C. Emotions
 - D. Time
- 4. In English, what is the only word containing all five vowels in alphabetical order?**
 - A. "Facetious"
 - B. "Education"
 - C. "Equations"
 - D. "Sequoia"
- 5. What language did Isaac Newton write "Principia Mathematica" in?**
 - A. English
 - B. French
 - C. German
 - D. Latin
- 6. Cockney rhyming slang uses pairs where the second word rhymes with the actual word. "Dog and bone" means:**
 - A. Home
 - B. Phone
 - C. Alone
 - D. Stone

- 7. What is the term for when a word changes part of speech (e.g. "to Google")?**
- A. Morphing
 - B. Conversion (or zero-derivation)
 - C. Conjugation
 - D. Inflection
- 8. Which letter was added to the English alphabet most recently?**
- A. J
 - B. W
 - C. Y
 - D. Z
- 9. The word "quiz" appeared in Dublin in 1791. According to legend, who introduced it?**
- A. A student
 - B. A theatre manager
 - C. A printer
 - D. A teacher
- 10. How many words did the average Shakespeare play use?**
- A. 5,000
 - B. 15,000
 - C. 25,000
 - D. 50,000
- 11. What is a hapax legomenon?**
- A. A Greek philosophical concept
 - B. A word that appears only once in a body of literature
 - C. A type of palindrome
 - D. A silent letter
- 12. The language Esperanto was invented in:**
- A. 1870
 - B. 1887
 - C. 1901
 - D. 1920
- 13. What is the term for the phenomenon where a word takes on a negative meaning over time?**
- A. Amelioration
 - B. Pejoration

- C. Narrowing
- D. Broadening

14. Which two languages does English derive most of its vocabulary from?

- A. Latin and Greek
- B. French and German
- C. French and Latin
- D. German and Norse

15. What is the world's oldest known written language?

- A. Egyptian hieroglyphics
- B. Sumerian cuneiform
- C. Sanskrit
- D. Chinese oracle script

MY SCORE:

Round 1: ____ / 10 Round 2: ____ / 10 Round 3: ____ / 10
Round 4: ____ / 15 **TOTAL: ____ / 45**

CHAPTER CLOSE *Language is the technology that made civilisation possible. Every idea you've ever had, every emotion you've ever named, every relationship you've built — all of it runs on words. Pay attention to them.*

CHAPTER 7 — ANSWER KEY

Round 2 — True or False

1. English gains approximately 1,000 new words every year.... → **TRUE**
2. Shakespeare invented over 1,700 words still in use.... → **TRUE**
3. The Hawaiian alphabet has 26 letters.... → **FALSE**
4. The longest English word is a type of medical condition.... → **TRUE**
5. Mandarin Chinese has approximately 50,000 characters.... → **TRUE**
6. English has fewer words than French.... → **FALSE**
7. All sign languages worldwide use the same grammar and signs.... → **FALSE**
8. The word "salary" derives from Roman payments made in salt.... → **TRUE**
9. Welsh traditionally had separate words for blue and green.... → **FALSE**
10. "E" is the most common letter in English.... → **TRUE**

Round 3 — Could You Have Guessed?

1. How many letters are in the Hawaiian alphabet? → **B. 13**
2. How many words does English have in current use? → **C. 170,000**
3. How many words did Shakespeare invent? → **C. Over 1,700**
4. What does "salary" literally derive from? → **C. Salt**
5. How many sign languages exist worldwide? → **D. Over 300**
6. How many Mandarin characters does an educated person ty → **B. 8,000–10,000**
7. The Welsh word "glas" covers which colours? → **B. Blue and green**
8. "E" appears in approximately what percentage of English → **C. 11%**
9. Which playwright is credited with inventing the word "e → **C. Shakespeare**
10. How many words does the average person actively use? → **B. 20,000–35,000**

Round 4 — Quick Fire

1. What language has the most native speakers? → **Mandarin Chinese**
2. What is the study of the origin of words called? → **Etymology**
3. What is the term for a word that sounds like what it describes? → **Onomatopoeia**
4. What literary device starts multiple words with the same consonant? → **Alliteration**
5. In how many languages has the Bible been translated? → **Over 700 (full Bible) — 3,000+ for portions**
6. What is a palindrome? → **A word or phrase that reads the same forwards and backwards**
7. What does the word "philosophy" mean in Greek? → **"Love of wisdom"**
8. What is the world's most translated document? → **The Universal Declaration of Human Rights**

9. What is the longest word in common everyday use in English? → **"Uncopyrightable" (15 letters, no repeated letters)**
10. What is an oxymoron? → **A figure of speech combining contradictory terms (e.g. "living death")**

Round 5 — Stump Your Friends!

1. How many languages are spoken worldwide? → **C. About 7,000**
2. What percentage of the world's languages are spoken by → **D. 60%**
3. The Piraha language of the Amazon has no words for: → **B. Numbers (has limited counting)**
4. In English, what is the only word containing all five v → **A. "Facetious"**
5. What language did Isaac Newton write "Principia Mathema → **D. Latin**
6. Cockney rhyming slang uses pairs where the second word → **B. Phone**
7. What is the term for when a word changes part of speech → **B. Conversion (or zero-derivation)**
8. Which letter was added to the English alphabet most rec → **A. J**
9. The word "quiz" appeared in Dublin in 1791. According t → **B. A theatre manager**
10. How many words did the average Shakespeare play use? → **B. 15,000**
11. What is a hapax legomenon? → **B. A word that appears only once in a body of literature**
12. The language Esperanto was invented in: → **B. 1887**
13. What is the term for the phenomenon where a word takes → **B. Pejoration**
14. Which two languages does English derive most of its voc → **C. French and Latin**
15. What is the world's oldest known written language? → **B. Sumerian cuneiform**

Halfway Through — And Your Mind Should Be Changed.

You have now completed seven chapters and encountered 70 Fact Bombs — any one of which should have made you stop and say "wait, really?" If you've learned something genuinely surprising, that's exactly what this book was designed to do.

FEEDBACK & CONTACT *Enjoyed the challenge? Share your feedback at snappgrid.com/contact.*

The second half begins on the next page.

Language · Money · Famous Minds · Geography · Pop Culture ·
Nature · Psychology · Numbers

CHAPTER 08 • UNBELIEVABLE BUT TRUE TRIVIA

Money, Power & Economics

Money is the world's most powerful fiction. Understanding how it actually works will change how you see everything.

ROUND 1 — FACT BOMBS

Read these 10 astonishing facts carefully. Your next rounds will test whether they landed.

FACT #1

The US government spent \$750,000 in 2019 researching whether cocaine makes quail more sexually promiscuous. This is a real federally funded study.

★ *Science goes where the questions are. Apparently.*

FACT #2

If you spent \$1 million every single day, it would take approximately 2,740 years to spend \$1 trillion. The US national debt exceeds \$35 trillion.

★ *Numbers this large are physically incomprehensible.*

FACT #3

The Monopoly board game was originally created in 1903 by Elizabeth Magie to demonstrate the dangers of monopoly capitalism. Parker Brothers later bought the rights and removed that message.

★ *The game about capitalism was designed to criticise capitalism.*

FACT #4

Bitcoin's creator, Satoshi Nakamoto, is unknown. The name is a pseudonym. The person or group behind it has never been identified, despite holding approximately \$50 billion in Bitcoin.

★ *The world's most successful anonymous inventor.*

FACT #5

The country of Zimbabwe issued a \$100 trillion dollar banknote in 2009 during hyperinflation. It was worth about \$30 USD at the time of issue.

★ *A hundred trillion dollars — barely enough for lunch.*

FACT #6

The world's first stock exchange, the Amsterdam Stock Exchange, was established in 1602 by the Dutch East India Company — the first company to issue public shares.

★ *Corporate capitalism began 400 years ago in Amsterdam.*

FACT #7

Warren Buffett earned 99% of his wealth after the age of 52. His net worth at 30 was \$1 million; by 60 it was \$3.8 billion; by 92 it exceeded \$100 billion.

★ *Compound interest running for decades is almost incomprehensible.*

FACT #8

In 2008, the global financial crisis erased approximately \$10 trillion in household wealth in the United States alone — in less than two years.

★ *Numbers that large make no intuitive sense — until the consequences do.*

FACT #9

The world's most expensive object ever sold is a painting — "Salvator Mundi" attributed to Leonardo da Vinci, which sold for \$450.3 million in 2017.

★ *A painting worth the GDP of several small countries.*

FACT #10

Norway's sovereign wealth fund — built from oil revenues — is the largest in the world at over \$1.7 trillion, giving every Norwegian citizen approximately \$320,000 in theoretical wealth.

★ *Oil money, saved instead of spent.*

ROUND 2**True or False (10 statements based on the Fact Bombs • 1 pt each)**

Mark each TRUE or FALSE — all answers relate to the facts you just read.

1. A US study funded research into whether cocaine affected quail's sexual behaviour.

TRUE / FALSE

2. It would take approximately 2,740 years to spend \$1 trillion at \$1 million per day.

TRUE / FALSE

3. Monopoly was originally designed to celebrate capitalism.

TRUE / FALSE

4. Bitcoin's creator Satoshi Nakamoto is known to be a single Japanese programmer.

TRUE / FALSE

5. Zimbabwe's \$100 trillion banknote was worth about \$30 at the time of issue.

TRUE / FALSE

6. The world's first stock exchange was in London.

TRUE / FALSE

7. Warren Buffett earned 99% of his wealth after age 52.

TRUE / FALSE

8. The 2008 financial crisis erased \$10 trillion in US household wealth in under two years.

TRUE / FALSE

9. "Salvator Mundi" sold for \$450.3 million in 2017.

TRUE / FALSE

10. Norway's sovereign wealth fund exceeds \$1.7 trillion.

TRUE / FALSE

ROUND 3**Could You Have Guessed? (10 multiple choice questions • 1 pt each)**

Four options — only one is correct.

1. Who originally created Monopoly in 1903?

A. Charles Darrow

- B. Parker Brothers
 - C. Elizabeth Magie
 - D. Milton Bradley
- 2. When was the Amsterdam Stock Exchange established?**
- A. 1492
 - B. 1550
 - C. 1602
 - D. 1700
- 3. What was Warren Buffett's net worth at age 30?**
- A. \$100,000
 - B. \$1 million
 - C. \$10 million
 - D. \$100 million
- 4. The Zimbabwe \$100 trillion note was issued in which year?**
- A. 2001
 - B. 2005
 - C. 2009
 - D. 2015
- 5. "Salvator Mundi" is attributed to which artist?**
- A. Raphael
 - B. Michelangelo
 - C. Leonardo da Vinci
 - D. Vermeer
- 6. Norway's sovereign wealth fund gives each citizen how much in theoretical wealth?**
- A. \$50,000
 - B. \$100,000
 - C. \$320,000
 - D. \$1 million
- 7. How long would \$1 million/day take to spend \$1 trillion?**
- A. 27 years
 - B. 274 years
 - C. 2,740 years
 - D. 27,400 years

8. Satoshi Nakamoto holds approximately how much in Bitcoin?

- A. \$1 billion
- B. \$10 billion
- C. \$50 billion
- D. \$100 billion

9. Which company issued the world's first public shares?

- A. East India Company (British)
- B. Dutch East India Company
- C. South Sea Company
- D. Fugger Banking House

10. What was the US government study on cocaine's effect on?

- A. Rats
- B. Pigeons
- C. Quail
- D. Monkeys

ROUND 4**Quick Fire (10 short-answer questions · 1 pt each)**

No options. Write your answer from memory.

- 1.** What does GDP stand for?

Answer:

- 2.** Which country has the world's largest economy by GDP?

Answer:

- 3.** What is inflation?

Answer:

- 4.** What is compound interest?

Answer:

- 5.** Who wrote "The Wealth of Nations"?

Answer:

- 6.** What is a bear market?

Answer:

- 7.** What country uses the euro as its currency?

Answer:

- 8.** What does IPO stand for?

Answer:

- 9.** Who is often called the "father of economics"?

Answer:

- 10.** What is the FTSE 100?

Answer:

ROUND 5**Stump Your Friends! (15 harder questions · 1 pt each)**

The round that separates the curious from the truly knowledgeable. No mercy.

1. What percentage of the world's wealth is held by the top 1%?

- A. 20%
- B. 38%
- C. 45%
- D. 50%+

2. The Federal Reserve was established in:

- A. 1865
- B. 1893
- C. 1913
- D. 1929

3. What is quantitative easing?

- A. Raising interest rates
- B. Central bank creating money to buy assets
- C. Reducing government debt
- D. Cutting public spending

4. The Bretton Woods system established which standard?

- A. Silver standard
- B. Gold standard for international trade
- C. Floating exchange rates
- D. Commodity-backed currencies

5. What is the Black-Scholes model used for?

- A. Pricing options and derivatives
- B. Calculating inflation
- C. Predicting stock crashes
- D. Measuring GDP

6. Gini coefficient measures:

- A. GDP per capita
- B. Economic growth rate
- C. Income inequality
- D. Employment levels

7. Which economist wrote "The General Theory of Employment, Interest and Money"?

- A. Hayek
- B. Friedman

- C. Keynes
- D. Galbraith

8. The Dutch Tulip Mania of 1637 is considered the world's first:

- A. Trade war
- B. Stock market crash
- C. Speculative bubble
- D. Currency crisis

9. What is a Ponzi scheme?

- A. A tax avoidance strategy
- B. Fraud paying old investors with new investor money
- C. A leveraged buyout
- D. A form of short-selling

10. Which country has the highest public debt as percentage of GDP?

- A. USA
- B. Greece
- C. Italy
- D. Japan

11. What does the Laffer Curve illustrate?

- A. Trade deficits vs growth
- B. Tax rate vs tax revenue relationship
- C. Inflation vs unemployment
- D. Interest rates vs investment

12. What was the South Sea Bubble?

- A. A piracy scandal
- B. A 1720s British speculative financial crisis
- C. A colonial trade failure
- D. A banking collapse in Amsterdam

13. The world's oldest central bank is:

- A. Bank of England
- B. Federal Reserve
- C. Riksbank (Sweden)
- D. Banque de France

14. What is stagflation?

- A. Fast growth with deflation
- B. High inflation combined with stagnant growth
- C. Rapid currency devaluation

D. Government debt crisis

15. Which index measures consumer price inflation in the US?

- A. DJIA
- B. S&P 500
- C. CPI
- D. PPI

MY SCORE: Round 1: ____/10 Round 2: ____/10 Round 3: ____/10
Round 4: ____/15 **TOTAL: ____/45**

CHAPTER CLOSE *Money is a shared story we all agree to tell. Its power lies entirely in collective belief. Understanding this is not cynicism — it is the beginning of genuine financial literacy.*

CHAPTER 8 — ANSWER KEY

Round 2 — True or False

1. A US study funded research into whether cocaine affected qua... → **TRUE**
2. It would take approximately 2,740 years to spend \$1 trillion... → **TRUE**
3. Monopoly was originally designed to celebrate capitalism.... → **FALSE**
4. Bitcoin's creator Satoshi Nakamoto is known to be a single J... → **FALSE**
5. Zimbabwe's \$100 trillion banknote was worth about \$30 at the... → **TRUE**
6. The world's first stock exchange was in London.... → **FALSE**
7. Warren Buffett earned 99% of his wealth after age 52.... → **TRUE**
8. The 2008 financial crisis erased \$10 trillion in US househol... → **TRUE**
9. "Salvator Mundi" sold for \$450.3 million in 2017.... → **TRUE**
10. Norway's sovereign wealth fund exceeds \$1.7 trillion.... → **TRUE**

Round 3 — Could You Have Guessed?

1. Who originally created Monopoly in 1903? → **C. Elizabeth Magie**
2. When was the Amsterdam Stock Exchange established? → **C. 1602**
3. What was Warren Buffett's net worth at age 30? → **B. \$1 million**
4. The Zimbabwe \$100 trillion note was issued in which yea → **C. 2009**
5. "Salvator Mundi" is attributed to which artist? → **C. Leonardo da Vinci**
6. Norway's sovereign wealth fund gives each citizen how m → **C. \$320,000**
7. How long would \$1 million/day take to spend \$1 trillion → **C. 2,740 years**
8. Satoshi Nakamoto holds approximately how much in Bitcoi → **C. \$50 billion**
9. Which company issued the world's first public shares? → **B. Dutch East India Company**
10. What was the US government study on cocaine's effect on → **C. Quail**

Round 4 — Quick Fire

1. What does GDP stand for? → **Gross Domestic Product**
2. Which country has the world's largest economy by GDP? → **United States (or China by PPP)**
3. What is inflation? → **The rate at which prices rise and purchasing power falls**
4. What is compound interest? → **Interest calculated on both the principal and previously accumulated interest**
5. Who wrote "The Wealth of Nations"? → **Adam Smith**
6. What is a bear market? → **A market in sustained decline (typically 20%+ fall)**
7. What country uses the euro as its currency? → **19 EU member states (accept any correct example)**
8. What does IPO stand for? → **Initial Public Offering**
9. Who is often called the "father of economics"? → **Adam Smith**

10. What is the FTSE 100? → An index of the 100 largest UK-listed companies by market capitalisation

Round 5 — Stump Your Friends!

- 1. What percentage of the world's wealth is held by the top 1%? → D. 50%+**
- 2. The Federal Reserve was established in: → C. 1913**
- 3. What is quantitative easing? → B. Central bank creating money to buy assets**
- 4. The Bretton Woods system established which standard? → B. Gold standard for international trade**
- 5. What is the Black-Scholes model used for? → A. Pricing options and derivatives**
- 6. Gini coefficient measures: → C. Income inequality**
- 7. Which economist wrote "The General Theory of Employment, Interest and Money"? → C. Keynes**
- 8. The Dutch Tulip Mania of 1637 is considered the world's first speculative bubble**
- 9. What is a Ponzi scheme? → B. Fraud paying old investors with new investor money**
- 10. Which country has the highest public debt as percentage of GDP? → D. Japan**
- 11. What does the Laffer Curve illustrate? → B. Tax rate vs tax revenue relationship**
- 12. What was the South Sea Bubble? → B. A 1720s British speculative financial crisis**
- 13. The world's oldest central bank is: → C. Riksbank (Sweden)**
- 14. What is stagflation? → B. High inflation combined with stagnant growth**
- 15. Which index measures consumer price inflation in the US? → C. CPI**

CHAPTER 09 • UNBELIEVABLE BUT TRUE TRIVIA

Famous Minds & Their Surprising Lives

The people who changed the world were not who history's tidy portraits suggest.

ROUND 1 — FACT BOMBS

Read these 10 astonishing facts carefully. Your next rounds will test whether they landed.

FACT #1

Isaac Newton suffered a nervous breakdown in 1693, writing bizarre, paranoid letters to friends, accusing them of persecution. The cause may have been mercury poisoning from his alchemical experiments.

★ *The father of physics may have been slowly poisoning himself.*

FACT #2

Nikola Tesla lived his last decade in a New York hotel room, became obsessed with pigeons, and died almost penniless — despite holding over 300 patents that powered the modern world.

★ *The man who invented AC power couldn't pay his bill.*

FACT #3

Charles Darwin waited 22 years after developing his theory of evolution to publish "On the Origin of Species" — partly from fear of the reaction, partly to build an overwhelming body of evidence.

★ *The most significant scientific theory in biology took 22 years of courage to publish.*

FACT #4

Albert Einstein failed his first entrance exam to the Swiss Federal Polytechnic School. He passed the

following year and went on to reshape our understanding of the universe.

★ *The man who rewrote physics was initially rejected.*

FACT #5

Ada Lovelace wrote the first computer algorithm in 1843 — over a century before the first working computer existed. She was working on Charles Babbage's theoretical "Analytical Engine."

★ *Computer science began with a poet's daughter.*

FACT #6

Winston Churchill won the Nobel Prize in Literature — not Peace — in 1953, for his six-volume "The Second World War" and other historical writings.

★ *The wartime Prime Minister was a Nobel-winning author.*

FACT #7

Leonardo da Vinci designed a functional robot in 1495 — a robotic knight that could sit, wave its arms, and move its jaw. Reconstructions built from his notes in the 1990s worked correctly.

★ *The Renaissance master was also a robotics engineer.*

FACT #8

Stephen Hawking was given two years to live when diagnosed with motor neurone disease at age 21. He survived 55 more years, dying at 76, and produced the majority of his work after the diagnosis.

★ *He outlived his prognosis by 53 years.*

FACT #9

Marie Curie's notebooks are still radioactive today — 100 years after her death. Researchers wishing to handle them must sign liability waivers. They are stored in lead-lined boxes.

★ *Her research material is still dangerous a century later.*

FACT #10

Beethoven composed his celebrated Ninth Symphony — including "Ode to Joy" — after he was completely deaf. He reportedly turned to face the audience during the premiere to see their applause, having heard nothing.

★ *The greatest symphony ever composed was created in total silence.*

ROUND 2**True or False** (10 statements based on the Fact Bombs • 1 pt each)

Mark each TRUE or FALSE — all answers relate to the facts you just read.

1. Newton's 1693 breakdown may have been caused by mercury poisoning.

TRUE / FALSE

2. Tesla died wealthy, having profited enormously from his patents.

TRUE / FALSE

3. Darwin waited 22 years to publish his theory of evolution.

TRUE / FALSE

4. Einstein passed his first entrance exam to the Swiss Polytechnic.

TRUE / FALSE

5. Ada Lovelace wrote the first computer algorithm in 1843.

TRUE / FALSE

6. Churchill won the Nobel Prize in Peace in 1953.

TRUE / FALSE

7. Da Vinci designed a working robotic knight in 1495.

TRUE / FALSE

8. Hawking was given two years to live at diagnosis and survived 55 more.

TRUE / FALSE

9. Marie Curie's notebooks are still radioactive today.

TRUE / FALSE

10. Beethoven was deaf when he composed the Ninth Symphony.

TRUE / FALSE

ROUND 3**Could You Have Guessed?** (10 multiple choice questions • 1 pt each)

Four options — only one is correct.

1. **What Nobel Prize did Churchill win?**

- A. Peace
- B. Economics

- C. Literature
 - D. Physics
- 2. How many patents did Nikola Tesla hold?**
- A. Over 50
 - B. Over 100
 - C. Over 200
 - D. Over 300
- 3. How long did Darwin wait to publish his theory?**
- A. 5 years
 - B. 10 years
 - C. 22 years
 - D. 30 years
- 4. Ada Lovelace's father was which famous poet?**
- A. Shelley
 - B. Keats
 - C. Byron
 - D. Wordsworth
- 5. How long did Hawking outlive his initial 2-year prognosis?**
- A. 10 years
 - B. 25 years
 - C. 40 years
 - D. 53 years
- 6. Where are Curie's notebooks stored?**
- A. In glass cases
 - B. In a vacuum
 - C. In lead-lined boxes
 - D. In digitised form only
- 7. What prompted Newton's possible mercury poisoning?**
- A. Dental work
 - B. Mining experiments
 - C. Alchemical experiments
 - D. Gunpowder research
- 8. Da Vinci's robotic knight designs were reconstructed in which decade?**
- A. 1960s
 - B. 1970s

C. 1980s

D. 1990s

9. Einstein initially failed entrance to which institution?

A. University of Berlin

B. Oxford University

C. Swiss Federal Polytechnic

D. University of Vienna

10. How old was Beethoven when he composed the Ninth Symphony?

A. In his 40s

B. In his 50s

C. In his 60s — and fully deaf

D. He was 30 — partially deaf

ROUND 4**Quick Fire (10 short-answer questions · 1 pt each)**

No options. Write your answer from memory.

- 1.** What was Einstein's famous equation?

Answer:

- 2.** Who invented the telephone?

Answer:

- 3.** Which scientist proposed the heliocentric model?

Answer:

- 4.** Who discovered penicillin?

Answer:

- 5.** What nationality was Tesla?

Answer:

- 6.** Which famous scientist spent years studying earthworms?

Answer:

- 7.** Who was the first woman to win a Nobel Prize?

Answer:

- 8.** What was Sigmund Freud's field?

Answer:

- 9.** Who developed the polio vaccine?

Answer:

- 10.** What nationality was da Vinci?

Answer:

ROUND 5**Stump Your Friends! (15 harder questions · 1 pt each)**

The round that separates the curious from the truly knowledgeable. No mercy.

- 1. Newton also spent years studying what subject alongside physics?**
 - A. Botany
 - B. Theology and alchemy
 - C. Politics
 - D. Medicine
- 2. Ramanujan, the self-taught mathematical genius, came from which country?**
 - A. China
 - B. Egypt
 - C. India
 - D. Turkey
- 3. Galileo was placed under house arrest for supporting which idea?**
 - A. Gravity
 - B. Heliocentrism
 - C. Atomic theory
 - D. Evolution
- 4. Einstein was offered the presidency of which country in 1952?**
 - A. Germany
 - B. USA
 - C. Switzerland
 - D. Israel
- 5. Which famous scientist held the same professorial chair as Newton at Cambridge?**
 - A. Dirac
 - B. Hawking
 - C. Rutherford
 - D. Thomson
- 6. Ada Lovelace worked with Charles Babbage on which machine?**
 - A. The Difference Engine only
 - B. The Analytical Engine
 - C. The Computing Engine
 - D. The Calculus Machine

- 7. What was Nikola Tesla's most audacious project?**
 - A. A death ray
 - B. Wireless global power transmission (Wardenclyffe Tower)
 - C. An electric aeroplane
 - D. A free energy machine
- 8. Darwin's "On the Origin of Species" was published in:**
 - A. 1839
 - B. 1845
 - C. 1859
 - D. 1871
- 9. Curie discovered which two elements?**
 - A. Uranium and Radium
 - B. Polonium and Radium
 - C. Thorium and Polonium
 - D. Radium and Francium
- 10. Beethoven's Ninth was his:**
 - A. Last symphony (correct)
 - B. Second-to-last symphony
 - C. Middle-period symphony
 - D. Only choral symphony
- 11. Which famous physicist said "God does not play dice with the universe"?**
 - A. Bohr
 - B. Heisenberg
 - C. Dirac
 - D. Einstein
- 12. What field did Florence Nightingale pioneer alongside nursing?**
 - A. Epidemiology
 - B. Statistical visualisation in healthcare
 - C. Psychology
 - D. Germ theory
- 13. Tesla's electrical current type (AC) competed with whose DC system?**
 - A. Westinghouse
 - B. Edison
 - C. Bell
 - D. Marconi

14. What did Newton famously observe (but did not discover from) a falling apple?

- A. Gravity's existence
- B. Gravity's universal law (law of gravitation)
- C. Acceleration due to gravity
- D. Terminal velocity

15. How many scientific papers did Einstein publish in his "miracle year" of 1905?

- A. One
- B. Two
- C. Four
- D. Ten

MY SCORE: Round 1: ____/10 Round 2: ____/10 Round 3: ____/10
Round 4: ____/15 **TOTAL: ____/45**

CHAPTER CLOSE *Genius is not a clean story. It is obsession, failure, courage, and extraordinary stubbornness. The people who changed the world were messy, contradictory, and very human.*

CHAPTER 9 — ANSWER KEY

Round 2 — True or False

1. Newton's 1693 breakdown may have been caused by mercury pois... → **TRUE**
2. Tesla died wealthy, having profited enormously from his pate... → **FALSE**
3. Darwin waited 22 years to publish his theory of evolution.... → **TRUE**
4. Einstein passed his first entrance exam to the Swiss Polytec... → **FALSE**
5. Ada Lovelace wrote the first computer algorithm in 1843.... → **TRUE**
6. Churchill won the Nobel Prize in Peace in 1953.... → **FALSE**
7. Da Vinci designed a working robotic knight in 1495.... → **TRUE**
8. Hawking was given two years to live at diagnosis and survive... → **TRUE**
9. Marie Curie's notebooks are still radioactive today.... → **TRUE**
10. Beethoven was deaf when he composed the Ninth Symphony.... → **TRUE**

Round 3 — Could You Have Guessed?

1. What Nobel Prize did Churchill win? → **C. Literature**
2. How many patents did Nikola Tesla hold? → **D. Over 300**
3. How long did Darwin wait to publish his theory? → **C. 22 years**
4. Ada Lovelace's father was which famous poet? → **C. Byron**
5. How long did Hawking outlive his initial 2-year prognos → **D. 53 years**
6. Where are Curie's notebooks stored? → **C. In lead-lined boxes**
7. What prompted Newton's possible mercury poisoning? → **C. Alchemical experiments**
8. Da Vinci's robotic knight designs were reconstructed in → **D. 1990s**
9. Einstein initially failed entrance to which institution → **C. Swiss Federal Polytechnic**
10. How old was Beethoven when he composed the Ninth Sympho → **B. In his 50s**

Round 4 — Quick Fire

1. What was Einstein's famous equation? → **$E = mc^2$**
2. Who invented the telephone? → **Alexander Graham Bell**
3. Which scientist proposed the heliocentric model? → **Copernicus (Nicolaus Copernicus)**
4. Who discovered penicillin? → **Alexander Fleming**
5. What nationality was Tesla? → **Serbian (born in modern Croatia)**
6. Which famous scientist spent years studying earthworms? → **Charles Darwin**
7. Who was the first woman to win a Nobel Prize? → **Marie Curie (Physics, 1903)**
8. What was Sigmund Freud's field? → **Psychiatry / psychoanalysis**
9. Who developed the polio vaccine? → **Jonas Salk**
10. What nationality was da Vinci? → **Italian (Florentine)**

Round 5 — Stump Your Friends!

1. Newton also spent years studying what subject alongside → **B. Theology and alchemy**
2. Ramanujan, the self-taught mathematical genius, came fr → **C. India**
3. Galileo was placed under house arrest for supporting wh → **B. Heliocentrism**
4. Einstein was offered the presidency of which country in → **D. Israel**
5. Which famous scientist held the same professorial chair → **B. Hawking**
6. Ada Lovelace worked with Charles Babbage on which machi → **B. The Analytical Engine**
7. What was Nikola Tesla's most audacious project? → **B. Wireless global power transmission (Wardenclyffe Tower)**
8. Darwin's "On the Origin of Species" was published in: → **C. 1859**
9. Curie discovered which two elements? → **B. Polonium and Radium**
10. Beethoven's Ninth was his: → **A. Last symphony (correct)**
11. Which famous physicist said "God does not play dice wit → **D. Einstein**
12. What field did Florence Nightingale pioneer alongside n → **B. Statistical visualisation in healthcare**
13. Tesla's electrical current type (AC) competed with whos → **B. Edison**
14. What did Newton famously observe (but did not discover → **B. Gravity's universal law (law of gravitation)**
15. How many scientific papers did Einstein publish in his → **C. Four**

CHAPTER 10 • UNBELIEVABLE BUT TRUE TRIVIA

Geography's Greatest Surprises

The world is not where you think it is, and it is not what you think it looks like.

ROUND 1 — FACT BOMBS

Read these 10 astonishing facts carefully. Your next rounds will test whether they landed.

FACT #1

Australia is wider than the Moon. Australia's east-west span is approximately 4,000 km; the Moon's diameter is 3,474 km.

★ *A continent wider than Earth's only natural satellite.*

FACT #2

Reno, Nevada is further west than Los Angeles, California. The shape of California means LA is east of Reno.

★ *Everything you think you know about US geography is wrong.*

FACT #3

The shortest international commercial flight in the world is between Westray and Papa Westray in Scotland — lasting just 90 seconds.

★ *Shorter than most TV adverts.*

FACT #4

There is a place in the United States where you can stand in four states simultaneously — Utah, Colorado, Arizona, and New Mexico — at the "Four Corners" monument.

★ *One body, four legal jurisdictions.*

FACT #5

Brazil borders every South American country except two: Chile and Ecuador.

★ *The largest country on the continent almost touches them all.*

FACT #6

Most of the world's maps are wrong. The Mercator projection — used in most classrooms — massively distorts size, making Greenland appear larger than Africa. Africa is actually 14 times larger.

★ *The map you grew up with is a deliberate distortion.*

FACT #7

The point on Earth's surface furthest from the centre of the Earth is not Everest — it is Mount Chimborazo in Ecuador, due to the Earth's equatorial bulge.

★ *The true "highest" mountain from Earth's core is in the Andes.*

FACT #8

Canada has more lakes than all other countries in the world combined — approximately 879,000 lakes, containing 20% of Earth's fresh water.

★ *Canada is essentially a country built on water.*

FACT #9

The Sahara Desert was green and habitable approximately 6,000 years ago. Cattle were herded and people lived there in settlements. Climate shifts turned it to desert in just centuries.

★ *The world's largest hot desert was once a savannah.*

FACT #10

The entirety of Russia — the world's largest country — has fewer people than Bangladesh, which is smaller than England.

★ *Population density makes geography meaningless as a measure of importance.*

ROUND 2**True or False** (10 statements based on the Fact Bombs • 1 pt each)

Mark each TRUE or FALSE — all answers relate to the facts you just read.

1. Australia is wider than the Moon.

TRUE / FALSE

2. Los Angeles is further west than Reno, Nevada.

TRUE / FALSE

3. The world's shortest commercial flight lasts approximately 90 seconds.

TRUE / FALSE

4. The Four Corners monument allows standing in five US states simultaneously.

TRUE / FALSE

5. Brazil borders every South American country except Chile and Ecuador.

TRUE / FALSE

6. The Mercator projection makes Greenland appear 14 times larger than Africa.

TRUE / FALSE

7. Mount Chimborazo is further from Earth's core than Mount Everest.

TRUE / FALSE

8. Canada has more lakes than all other countries combined.

TRUE / FALSE

9. The Sahara was green and inhabited approximately 6,000 years ago.

TRUE / FALSE

10. Russia has a larger population than Bangladesh.

TRUE / FALSE

ROUND 3**Could You Have Guessed?** (10 multiple choice questions • 1 pt each)

Four options — only one is correct.

- 1. How much wider is Australia than the Moon in approximate km?**
 - A. Australia is smaller
 - B. Same size
 - C. 500 km wider
 - D. Australia is ~4,000 km; Moon ~3,474 km
- 2. The world's shortest commercial flight is in which country?**
 - A. Ireland
 - B. Scotland
 - C. Norway
 - D. Iceland
- 3. How many lakes does Canada have approximately?**
 - A. 100,000
 - B. 500,000
 - C. 879,000
 - D. 2 million
- 4. How many times larger is Africa than it appears on Mercator maps compared to Greenland?**
 - A. 3 times
 - B. 7 times
 - C. 14 times
 - D. 25 times
- 5. The Sahara became desert approximately how many years ago?**
 - A. 1,000
 - B. 3,000
 - C. 6,000
 - D. 15,000
- 6. Which states meet at the Four Corners?**
 - A. Utah, Colorado, Wyoming, New Mexico
 - B. Utah, Colorado, Arizona, New Mexico
 - C. Nevada, Utah, Arizona, Colorado
 - D. Idaho, Utah, Wyoming, Colorado
- 7. South American countries NOT bordered by Brazil:**
 - A. Argentina and Chile
 - B. Chile and Ecuador
 - C. Bolivia and Venezuela

D. Guyana and Suriname

8. What percentage of Earth's fresh water does Canada hold?

- A. 5%**
- B. 10%**
- C. 20%**
- D. 35%**

9. Why is Chimborazo "taller" than Everest in one sense?

- A. It's in the atmosphere**
- B. Earth's equatorial bulge**
- C. It's on a higher plateau**
- D. Sea level reference point**

10. Bangladesh's area is comparable to which country?

- A. France**
- B. Germany**
- C. England**
- D. Italy**

ROUND 4**Quick Fire (10 short-answer questions · 1 pt each)**

No options. Write your answer from memory.

- 1.** What is the capital of Canada?

Answer:

- 2.** Which country has the longest coastline?

Answer:

- 3.** On which continent would you find the Atacama Desert?

Answer:

- 4.** What is the world's largest ocean?

Answer:

- 5.** Which country is home to the most UNESCO World Heritage Sites?

Answer:

- 6.** What is the deepest lake in the world?

Answer:

- 7.** Which city is furthest north: Moscow, London, or Edinburgh?

Answer:

- 8.** What is the largest country in Africa by area?

Answer:

- 9.** What sea lies between Greece and Turkey?

Answer:

- 10.** What is the smallest country in the world?

Answer:

ROUND 5**Stump Your Friends! (15 harder questions · 1 pt each)**

The round that separates the curious from the truly knowledgeable. No mercy.

- 1. At the current rate of plate movement, which two continents will collide in about 50 million years?**
 - A. Africa and Europe
 - B. Australia and Asia
 - C. North and South America
 - D. India and Russia
- 2. The Amazon River discharges approximately what fraction of all river water entering the world's oceans?**
 - A. 5%
 - B. 10%
 - C. 15%
 - D. 20%
- 3. Which country has the most time zones?**
 - A. Russia
 - B. USA
 - C. China
 - D. France
- 4. What is the Ring of Fire?**
 - A. A volcanic and seismic belt around the Pacific
 - B. A band of desert across Asia
 - C. A trade route through the Middle East
 - D. A climate zone near the equator
- 5. How many countries are in the African continent?**
 - A. 42
 - B. 48
 - C. 54
 - D. 61
- 6. The Dead Sea is how many metres below sea level (approximately)?**
 - A. 100 m
 - B. 250 m
 - C. 430 m
 - D. 600 m
- 7. Which river is longer: the Nile or the Amazon?**
 - A. The Nile (definitively)
 - B. The Amazon (definitively)

- C. They are the same length
 - D. It depends on how measured
- 8. What percentage of Earth's land area is permanently covered by ice?**
- A. 3%
 - B. 10%
 - C. 18%
 - D. 28%
- 9. The Great Barrier Reef is visible from:**
- A. The Moon
 - B. Orbit from the ISS
 - C. Ground level only
 - D. Cannot be seen from above the atmosphere
- 10. Which mountain range contains the world's 14 tallest peaks?**
- A. The Alps
 - B. The Andes
 - C. The Himalayas
 - D. The Rockies
- 11. How many of the world's countries are landlocked?**
- A. 18
 - B. 30
 - C. 44
 - D. 62
- 12. The Caspian Sea is technically classified as:**
- A. A sea
 - B. An ocean
 - C. A lake
 - D. A gulf
- 13. What is the name of the tectonic plate that carries India?**
- A. Eurasian Plate
 - B. Indo-Australian Plate
 - C. Indian Plate
 - D. Deccan Plate
- 14. Which ocean has the most islands?**
- A. Atlantic
 - B. Indian

- C. Arctic
- D. Pacific

15. Approximately what percentage of Earth's surface is ocean?

- A. 51%
- B. 61%
- C. 71%
- D. 81%

MY SCORE: Round 1: ____ /10 Round 2: ____ /10 Round 3: ____ /10
Round 4: ____ /15 **TOTAL: ____ /45**

CHAPTER CLOSE *The Earth is not a backdrop to human history — it is its main character. Civilisations rose and fell based on geography: rivers, coastlines, mountain passes, and soil quality. You cannot understand history without understanding the land it happened on.*

CHAPTER 10 — ANSWER KEY

Round 2 — True or False

1. Australia is wider than the Moon.... → **TRUE**
2. Los Angeles is further west than Reno, Nevada.... → **FALSE**
3. The world's shortest commercial flight lasts approximately 9... → **TRUE**
4. The Four Corners monument allows standing in five US states ... → **FALSE**
5. Brazil borders every South American country except Chile and... → **TRUE**
6. The Mercator projection makes Greenland appear 14 times larg... → **FALSE**
7. Mount Chimborazo is further from Earth's core than Mount Eve... → **TRUE**
8. Canada has more lakes than all other countries combined.... → **TRUE**
9. The Sahara was green and inhabited approximately 6,000 years... → **TRUE**
10. Russia has a larger population than Bangladesh.... → **FALSE**

Round 3 — Could You Have Guessed?

1. How much wider is Australia than the Moon in approximat → **D. Australia is ~4,000 km; Moon ~3,474 km**
2. The world's shortest commercial flight is in which coun → **B. Scotland**
3. How many lakes does Canada have approximately? → **C. 879,000**
4. How many times larger is Africa than it appears on Merc → **C. 14 times**
5. The Sahara became desert approximately how many years a → **C. 6,000**
6. Which states meet at the Four Corners? → **B. Utah, Colorado, Arizona, New Mexico**
7. South American countries NOT bordered by Brazil: → **B. Chile and Ecuador**
8. What percentage of Earth's fresh water does Canada hold → **C. 20%**
9. Why is Chimborazo "taller" than Everest in one sense? → **B. Earth's equatorial bulge**
10. Bangladesh's area is comparable to which country? → **C. England**

Round 4 — Quick Fire

1. What is the capital of Canada? → **Ottawa**
2. Which country has the longest coastline? → **Canada**
3. On which continent would you find the Atacama Desert? → **South America**
4. What is the world's largest ocean? → **The Pacific Ocean**
5. Which country is home to the most UNESCO World Heritage Sites? → **Italy (or China — both are top)**
6. What is the deepest lake in the world? → **Lake Baikal (Russia)**
7. Which city is furthest north: Moscow, London, or Edinburgh? → **Moscow (and actually Oslo — but of these three, Moscow)**
8. What is the largest country in Africa by area? → **Algeria**
9. What sea lies between Greece and Turkey? → **The Aegean Sea**
10. What is the smallest country in the world? → **Vatican City**

Round 5 — Stump Your Friends!

1. At the current rate of plate movement, which two contin → **B. Australia and Asia**
2. The Amazon River discharges approximately what fraction → **D. 20%**
3. Which country has the most time zones? → **D. France**
4. What is the Ring of Fire? → **A. A volcanic and seismic belt around the Pacific**
5. How many countries are in the African continent? → **C. 54**
6. The Dead Sea is how many metres below sea level (approx → **C. 430 m**
7. Which river is longer: the Nile or the Amazon? → **D. It depends on how measured**
8. What percentage of Earth's land area is permanently cov → **B. 10%**
9. The Great Barrier Reef is visible from: → **B. Orbit from the ISS**
10. Which mountain range contains the world's 14 tallest pe → **C. The Himalayas**
11. How many of the world's countries are landlocked? → **C. 44**
12. The Caspian Sea is technically classified as: → **C. A lake**
13. What is the name of the tectonic plate that carries Ind → **C. Indian Plate**
14. Which ocean has the most islands? → **D. Pacific**
15. Approximately what percentage of Earth's surface is oce → **C. 71%**

CHAPTER 11 • UNBELIEVABLE BUT TRUE TRIVIA

Pop Culture's Hidden Truth

The entertainment industry is full of stories behind the stories. Almost nothing is quite what it appeared.

ROUND 1 — FACT BOMBS

Read these 10 astonishing facts carefully. Your next rounds will test whether they landed.

FACT #1

The "007" designation in James Bond was chosen by Ian Fleming. He was inspired by the bus route 007 in Jamaica that he rode during his time writing the novels there.

★ *The world's most famous secret agent number came from a bus timetable.*

FACT #2

The original Star Wars film was rejected by every major Hollywood studio before 20th Century Fox agreed to distribute it. George Lucas retained merchandising rights — which proved worth billions.

★ *The studios that said no gave away one of the most valuable licensing deals in history.*

FACT #3

Walt Disney was rejected 302 times before finally getting a bank loan to build Disneyland. His concept was called "a dangerous financial folly" by industry experts.

★ *302 rejections. Then the most visited theme park on Earth.*

FACT #4

The Rolling Stones song "Satisfaction" was written by Keith Richards in his sleep. He woke to find the riff

recorded on a cassette player beside his bed, with 45 minutes of snoring after it.

★ *One of rock's greatest riffs was created unconsciously.*

FACT #5

Alfred Hitchcock appears briefly in 39 of his 52 surviving films as a background extra — a tradition that became one of cinema's most famous running jokes.

★ *Hitchcock was technically in more films than any of his stars.*

FACT #6

The Harry Potter series was rejected by 12 publishers before Bloomsbury accepted it. Bloomsbury's editor took it home and his 8-year-old daughter demanded the next chapter — sealing the deal.

★ *A child saved the most successful book series in history.*

FACT #7

The Simpsons has correctly "predicted" numerous real-world events decades before they happened, including smartwatches, video calls, a Trump presidency, and the Higgs boson discovery.

★ *A cartoon has a better predictive record than most think tanks.*

FACT #8

The "F word" appears 265 times in "The Wolf of Wall Street" — a record for any film at the time of release (2013). It was surpassed by "Uncut Gems" in 2019.

★ *Some films are statistically as profane as a building site.*

FACT #9

"Bohemian Rhapsody" by Queen was initially rejected by radio stations as too long and uncommercial. It ran at nearly 6 minutes — nearly double the standard pop song length.

★ *The most played song in the 20th century was nearly never played.*

FACT #10

The iconic shower scene in Psycho (1960) took 7 days to film, used 70 camera setups, and 78 cuts — for a 45-second sequence. No actual nudity appears on screen.

★ *Cinema's most famous scene of implied violence was a masterclass in suggestion.*

ROUND 2**True or False (10 statements based on the Fact Bombs • 1 pt each)**

Mark each TRUE or FALSE — all answers relate to the facts you just read.

- 1.** The "007" number was inspired by a bus route Fleming rode in Jamaica.

TRUE / FALSE

- 2.** George Lucas sold his Star Wars merchandising rights to the studios.

TRUE / FALSE

- 3.** Walt Disney was rejected over 300 times for Disneyland funding.

TRUE / FALSE

- 4.** "Satisfaction" by The Rolling Stones was written by Keith Richards while asleep.

TRUE / FALSE

- 5.** Hitchcock appears in all 52 of his surviving films.

TRUE / FALSE

- 6.** Harry Potter was rejected by 12 publishers.

TRUE / FALSE

- 7.** The Simpsons has never predicted any real-world events.

TRUE / FALSE

- 8.** "Bohemian Rhapsody" was initially embraced by radio stations for its commercial appeal.

TRUE / FALSE

- 9.** The Psycho shower scene was filmed over 7 days with 78 cuts.

TRUE / FALSE

- 10.** "The Wolf of Wall Street" set a record for use of profanity at the time of release.

TRUE / FALSE

ROUND 3**Could You Have Guessed? (10 multiple choice questions • 1 pt each)**

Four options — only one is correct.

- 1. How many publishers rejected Harry Potter?**

- A. 4
 - B. 8
 - C. 12
 - D. 20
- 2. How many times did Disney get rejected for Disneyland?**
- A. 52
 - B. 150
 - C. 302
 - D. 500
- 3. In how many of his films does Hitchcock appear?**
- A. 15
 - B. 27
 - C. 39
 - D. all 52
- 4. "Satisfaction"'s opening riff was recorded on a:**
- A. Reel-to-reel
 - B. 8-track
 - C. Cassette player
 - D. Dictaphone
- 5. 007's name was inspired by a bus route in which country?**
- A. England
 - B. Scotland
 - C. Jamaica
 - D. Bahamas
- 6. "Bohemian Rhapsody" ran at nearly how long?**
- A. 3 minutes
 - B. 4.5 minutes
 - C. 6 minutes
 - D. 8 minutes
- 7. The Psycho shower scene took how many days to film?**
- A. One day
 - B. 3 days
 - C. 7 days
 - D. 2 weeks
- 8. Who made the decision to publish Harry Potter at Bloomsbury?**

- A. The CEO
- B. A literary agent
- C. An editor whose daughter loved it
- D. The marketing department

9. George Lucas's deal to retain Star Wars merchandising rights was worth:

- A. Millions
- B. Hundreds of millions
- C. Billions
- D. He sold them eventually

10. Which studio rejected Star Wars before Fox agreed?

- A. Every major studio
- B. Only Universal
- C. Only Paramount
- D. Only Warner Bros

ROUND 4**Quick Fire (10 short-answer questions · 1 pt each)**

No options. Write your answer from memory.

- 1.** Who directed the original Star Wars (1977)?

Answer:

- 2.** Which TV show has run the longest in US primetime history?

Answer:

- 3.** Who played James Bond first in film?

Answer:

- 4.** What was the best-selling album of the 20th century?

Answer:

- 5.** What year was the first Harry Potter book published?

Answer:

- 6.** Who directed Psycho?

Answer:

- 7.** What band recorded "Bohemian Rhapsody"?

Answer:

- 8.** Who created The Simpsons?

Answer:

- 9.** In which decade was Disneyland first opened?

Answer:

- 10.** What is the name of James Bond's creator?

Answer:

ROUND 5**Stump Your Friends! (15 harder questions · 1 pt each)**

The round that separates the curious from the truly knowledgeable. No mercy.

- 1. The first feature-length animated film was produced by Disney in:**
 - A. 1928
 - B. 1934
 - C. 1937
 - D. 1942
- 2. "Casablanca"'s famous line "Play it again, Sam" was:**
 - A. Spoken exactly as remembered
 - B. Never actually said in the film
 - C. Said by Sam, not Rick
 - D. Said by Ingrid Bergman
- 3. The character Sherlock Holmes never says "Elementary, my dear Watson" in:**
 - A. One novel
 - B. Several novels
 - C. The original Conan Doyle stories
 - D. The stage adaptations
- 4. The highest-grossing film of all time (not adjusted for inflation as of 2025) is:**
 - A. Titanic
 - B. Avengers: Endgame
 - C. Top Gun: Maverick
 - D. Avatar (2009)
- 5. "The Beatles" name was a play on which other band's name?**
 - A. The Crickets (Buddy Holly)
 - B. The Shadows
 - C. The Everly Brothers
 - D. The Quarrymen
- 6. How many Academy Awards did "Titanic" win?**
 - A. 7
 - B. 9
 - C. 11
 - D. 14
- 7. The first televised presidential debate in the US was between:**

- A. Roosevelt and Dewey
- B. Eisenhower and Stevenson
- C. Nixon and Kennedy
- D. Carter and Reagan

8. What percentage of films released in Hollywood make a theatrical profit?

- A. About 70%
- B. About 50%
- C. About 30%
- D. About 20%

9. The famous Marilyn Monroe dress (subway grate scene) was from which film?

- A. Some Like It Hot
- B. Gentlemen Prefer Blondes
- C. The Seven Year Itch
- D. Bus Stop

10. Which band holds the record for most number one albums in UK chart history?

- A. The Beatles
- B. Rolling Stones
- C. Elvis Presley
- D. Robbie Williams

11. "Thriller" by Michael Jackson stayed on the Billboard charts for how long?

- A. 1 year
- B. 2 years
- C. 3 years
- D. Still charting periodically in 2025

12. The Oscars Best Picture award was first given in:

- A. 1927
- B. 1929
- C. 1934
- D. 1939

13. Which director holds the record for most Oscar wins (as director)?

- A. Spielberg
- B. Kubrick
- C. John Ford

D. William Wyler

14. The original "Top Gun" (1986) reignited US Navy recruitment by approximately how much?

- A. 10%
- B. 25%
- C. 50%
- D. 500%

15. What was the working title of "Casablanca" during production?

- A. Morocco
- B. Everybody Comes to Rick's
- C. Desert Rose
- D. The White City

MY SCORE: Round 1: ____/10 Round 2: ____/10 Round 3: ____/10
Round 4: ____/10 **TOTAL: ____/45**

CHAPTER CLOSE *Entertainment is not separate from history — it shapes it. The stories a culture tells itself about heroes, villains, love, and death determine what that culture values and how it acts. Fiction is serious business.*

CHAPTER 11 — ANSWER KEY

Round 2 — True or False

1. The "007" number was inspired by a bus route Fleming rode in... → **TRUE**
2. George Lucas sold his Star Wars merchandising rights to the ... → **FALSE**
3. Walt Disney was rejected over 300 times for Disneyland fundi... → **TRUE**
4. "Satisfaction" by The Rolling Stones was written by Keith Ri... → **TRUE**
5. Hitchcock appears in all 52 of his surviving films.... → **FALSE**
6. Harry Potter was rejected by 12 publishers.... → **TRUE**
7. The Simpsons has never predicted any real-world events.... → **FALSE**
8. "Bohemian Rhapsody" was initially embraced by radio stations... → **FALSE**
9. The Psycho shower scene was filmed over 7 days with 78 cuts.... → **TRUE**
10. "The Wolf of Wall Street" set a record for use of profanity ... → **TRUE**

Round 3 — Could You Have Guessed?

1. How many publishers rejected Harry Potter? → **C. 12**
2. How many times did Disney get rejected for Disneyland? → **C. 302**
3. In how many of his films does Hitchcock appear? → **C. 39**
4. "Satisfaction"'s opening riff was recorded on a: → **C. Cassette player**
5. 007's name was inspired by a bus route in which country → **C. Jamaica**
6. "Bohemian Rhapsody" ran at nearly how long? → **C. 6 minutes**
7. The Psycho shower scene took how many days to film? → **C. 7 days**
8. Who made the decision to publish Harry Potter at Blooms → **C. An editor whose daughter loved it**
9. George Lucas's deal to retain Star Wars merchandising r → **C. Billions**
10. Which studio rejected Star Wars before Fox agreed? → **A. Every major studio**

Round 4 — Quick Fire

1. Who directed the original Star Wars (1977)? → **George Lucas**
2. Which TV show has run the longest in US primetime history? → **The Simpsons**
3. Who played James Bond first in film? → **Sean Connery**
4. What was the best-selling album of the 20th century? → **Thriller — Michael Jackson**
5. What year was the first Harry Potter book published? → **1997**
6. Who directed Psycho? → **Alfred Hitchcock**
7. What band recorded "Bohemian Rhapsody"? → **Queen**
8. Who created The Simpsons? → **Matt Groening**
9. In which decade was Disneyland first opened? → **1950s (1955)**
10. What is the name of James Bond's creator? → **Ian Fleming**

Round 5 — Stump Your Friends!

1. The first feature-length animated film was produced by → **C. 1937**
2. "Casablanca"'s famous line "Play it again, Sam" was: → **B. Never actually said in the film**
3. The character Sherlock Holmes never says "Elementary, m → **C. The original Conan Doyle stories**
4. The highest-grossing film of all time (not adjusted for → **D. Avatar (2009)**
5. "The Beatles" name was a play on which other band's nam → **A. The Crickets (Buddy Holly)**
6. How many Academy Awards did "Titanic" win? → **C. 11**
7. The first televised presidential debate in the US was b → **C. Nixon and Kennedy**
8. What percentage of films released in Hollywood make a t → **D. About 20%**
9. The famous Marilyn Monroe dress (subway grate scene) wa → **C. The Seven Year Itch**
10. Which band holds the record for most number one albums → **A. The Beatles**
11. "Thriller" by Michael Jackson stayed on the Billboard c → **D. Still charting periodically in 2025**
12. The Oscars Best Picture award was first given in: → **B. 1929**
13. Which director holds the record for most Oscar wins (as → **C. John Ford**
14. The original "Top Gun" (1986) reignited US Navy recruit → **C. 50%**
15. What was the working title of "Casablanca" during produ → **B. Everybody Comes to Rick's**

CHAPTER 12 • UNBELIEVABLE BUT TRUE TRIVIA

The Natural World's Strangest Secrets

Nature is not following rules you understand. It is following rules so strange they are almost impossible to believe.

ROUND 1 — FACT BOMBS

Read these 10 astonishing facts carefully. Your next rounds will test whether they landed.

FACT #1

Trees in a forest communicate with each other through underground fungal networks — sometimes called the "Wood Wide Web." They share nutrients and send chemical warning signals.

★ *Forests are not collections of individual trees. They are connected superorganisms.*

FACT #2

Lightning strikes the Earth approximately 100 times per second — about 8 million times per day. The Empire State Building alone is struck about 25 times per year.

★ *The sky is constantly exploding above us.*

FACT #3

Glass is not a solid — it is technically an amorphous solid, or a supercooled liquid. Ancient glass panes appear thicker at the bottom not because glass flows, but because of how they were made.

★ *The windows in medieval churches are not melting. But glass is stranger than it appears.*

FACT #4

Volcanoes can produce lightning — called "dirty thunderstorms" or volcanic lightning. The ash and

debris create static electricity resulting in lightning bolts within the eruption column.

★ *A volcano and a thunderstorm simultaneously. In one place.*

FACT #5

The Earth's magnetic poles are currently moving. The North Magnetic Pole has shifted over 1,000 km since 1900 and is accelerating. Compasses are becoming less reliable in the Arctic.

★ *True North is a moving target.*

FACT #6

A single litre of seawater contains approximately one million bacteria, ten million viruses, and thousands of microorganisms. The ocean is the densest ecosystem on Earth.

★ *Every mouthful of sea water is an entire ecosystem.*

FACT #7

The oldest living thing on Earth is a bristlecone pine called "Methuselah" — approximately 4,855 years old, growing in California. It was already 355 years old when the Great Pyramid was built.

★ *It predates almost all of recorded human history.*

FACT #8

Rainforests produce their own rain. Moisture evaporated from the canopy condenses, forms clouds, and falls back as rain in a cycle that sustains itself — until enough trees are removed.

★ *The Amazon generates roughly half its own rainfall.*

FACT #9

Earthquakes can change the length of an Earth day. The 2011 Japan earthquake shortened Earth's day by 1.8 microseconds by redistributing the planet's mass.

★ *A fault line can alter time itself.*

FACT #10

Ice cores drilled from Antarctic glaciers contain air bubbles with ancient atmosphere — allowing scientists to measure CO₂ levels, temperatures, and volcanic events from 800,000 years ago.

★ *The past's atmosphere is literally frozen inside the ice.*

ROUND 2**True or False (10 statements based on the Fact Bombs • 1 pt each)**

Mark each TRUE or FALSE — all answers relate to the facts you just read.

- 1.** Trees communicate with each other through underground fungal networks.

TRUE / FALSE

- 2.** Lightning strikes the Earth approximately 100 times per second.

TRUE / FALSE

- 3.** Ancient glass panes are thicker at the bottom because glass slowly flows over centuries.

TRUE / FALSE

- 4.** Volcanic lightning is caused by static electricity in ash columns.

TRUE / FALSE

- 5.** The Earth's magnetic poles are stationary and have been for centuries.

TRUE / FALSE

- 6.** A litre of seawater contains approximately one million bacteria.

TRUE / FALSE

- 7.** The Methuselah bristlecone pine is approximately 4,855 years old.

TRUE / FALSE

- 8.** Rainforests generate roughly half of their own rainfall.

TRUE / FALSE

- 9.** The 2011 Japan earthquake shortened Earth's day by 1.8 microseconds.

TRUE / FALSE

- 10.** Ice cores can reveal atmospheric data from up to 800,000 years ago.

TRUE / FALSE

ROUND 3**Could You Have Guessed? (10 multiple choice questions • 1 pt each)**

Four options — only one is correct.

- 1. What is the "Wood Wide Web"?**
 - A. A tree communication app
 - B. Underground fungal networks linking trees
 - C. Root-based water sharing
 - D. Chemical signals through pollen
- 2. How many times per day does lightning strike Earth?**
 - A. 80,000
 - B. 800,000
 - C. 8 million
 - D. 80 million
- 3. What causes volcanic lightning?**
 - A. High altitude winds
 - B. Heat convection
 - C. Static electricity from ash and debris
 - D. Eruption pressure waves
- 4. How much has the North Magnetic Pole shifted since 1900?**
 - A. 100 km
 - B. 500 km
 - C. Over 1,000 km
 - D. Over 5,000 km
- 5. How old is the Methuselah bristlecone pine?**
 - A. 2,000 years
 - B. 3,500 years
 - C. 4,855 years
 - D. 6,000 years
- 6. How far back can ice cores measure atmospheric data?**
 - A. 50,000 years
 - B. 200,000 years
 - C. 500,000 years
 - D. 800,000 years
- 7. The 2011 Japan earthquake changed Earth's day by:**
 - A. 0.1 microseconds
 - B. 1.8 microseconds
 - C. 5 microseconds
 - D. 1 second
- 8. Where is the Methuselah tree located?**

- A. Oregon
- B. Nevada
- C. California
- D. Colorado

9. How many viruses are in approximately one litre of seawater?

- A. 10,000
- B. 1 million
- C. 10 million
- D. 1 billion

10. Glass is technically described as:

- A. A brittle solid
- B. A slow-flowing liquid
- C. An amorphous solid / supercooled liquid
- D. A crystalline structure

ROUND 4**Quick Fire (10 short-answer questions · 1 pt each)**

No options. Write your answer from memory.

- 1.** What is the world's largest living organism?

Answer:

- 2.** What percentage of Earth's species live in the ocean?

Answer:

- 3.** What is the name for the underground fungal network linking trees?

Answer:

- 4.** What causes the Northern Lights (Aurora Borealis)?

Answer:

- 5.** How hot is a lightning bolt?

Answer:

- 6.** What is the fastest wind speed ever recorded on Earth?

Answer:

- 7.** What is the loudest natural sound ever recorded?

Answer:

- 8.** What percentage of Earth's fresh water is frozen in ice caps?

Answer:

- 9.** Which type of cloud is the tallest?

Answer:

- 10.** How long has life existed on Earth approximately?

Answer:

ROUND 5**Stump Your Friends! (15 harder questions · 1 pt each)**

The round that separates the curious from the truly knowledgeable. No mercy.

1. Fungi are more closely related to which kingdom?

- A. Plants
- B. Bacteria
- C. Animals
- D. Protists

2. The Cambrian Explosion approximately 541 million years ago refers to:

- A. A mass extinction
- B. A rapid diversification of complex animal life
- C. A volcanic event
- D. A climate catastrophe

3. What is the Coriolis effect?

- A. Ocean current cooling
- B. Deflection of moving objects due to Earth's rotation
- C. Magnetic pole drift
- D. Atmospheric pressure gradient

4. What is the albedo effect?

- A. Ocean warming from sunlight
- B. Reflection of solar radiation by surfaces like ice
- C. Carbon absorption by forests
- D. Volcanic cooling of atmosphere

5. The deepest point on Earth is the Challenger Deep. How deep is it?

- A. 5 km
- B. 8 km
- C. 11 km
- D. 15 km

6. What percentage of Earth's species are estimated to be undiscovered?

- A. 5%
- B. 15%
- C. 50%
- D. 80%+

7. Permafrost covers approximately what percentage of Earth's land surface?

- A. 5%

- B. 17%
 - C. 25%
 - D. 35%
- 8. What is the most abundant mineral in Earth's mantle?**
- A. Quartz
 - B. Olivine
 - C. Feldspar
 - D. Bridgmanite
- 9. Ocean currents are driven primarily by:**
- A. Wind only
 - B. Temperature, salinity and wind
 - C. Moon's gravity
 - D. Earth's rotation only
- 10. The Great Oxidation Event approximately 2.4 billion years ago refers to:**
- A. A volcanic catastrophe
 - B. The first mass extinction
 - C. The rise of photosynthesis and oxygen in atmosphere
 - D. A meteor impact
- 11. Which gas makes up the majority of Earth's atmosphere?**
- A. Oxygen (21%)
 - B. Argon (1%)
 - C. Carbon dioxide
 - D. Nitrogen (78%)
- 12. What is the name for the boundary between Earth's crust and mantle?**
- A. The Lithosphere
 - B. The Mohorovičić discontinuity
 - C. The Gutenberg discontinuity
 - D. The Conrad discontinuity
- 13. How fast do tectonic plates typically move?**
- A. 1 mm per year
 - B. 1–10 cm per year
 - C. 1 metre per year
 - D. 10 metres per year
- 14. What type of rock makes up the majority of Earth's oceanic crust?**

- A. Granite
- B. Limestone
- C. Basalt
- D. Sandstone

15. The Amazon Basin contains approximately what percentage of all plant and animal species on Earth?

- A. 5%
- B. 10%
- C. 20%
- D. 30%

MY SCORE: Round 1: / 10 Round 2: / 10 Round 3: / 10
Round 4: / 10 **TOTAL:** / 45

CHAPTER CLOSE *The natural world is not scenery. It is a four-billion-year experiment in complexity, cooperation, and survival. We are not observers of nature — we are one of its outcomes, temporary and dependent on everything around us.*

CHAPTER 12 — ANSWER KEY

Round 2 — True or False

1. Trees communicate with each other through underground fungal... → **TRUE**
2. Lightning strikes the Earth approximately 100 times per seco... → **TRUE**
3. Ancient glass panes are thicker at the bottom because glass ... → **FALSE**
4. Volcanic lightning is caused by static electricity in ash co... → **TRUE**
5. The Earth's magnetic poles are stationary and have been for ... → **FALSE**
6. A litre of seawater contains approximately one million bacte... → **TRUE**
7. The Methuselah bristlecone pine is approximately 4,855 years... → **TRUE**
8. Rainforests generate roughly half of their own rainfall.... → **TRUE**
9. The 2011 Japan earthquake shortened Earth's day by 1.8 micro... → **TRUE**
10. Ice cores can reveal atmospheric data from up to 800,000 yea... → **TRUE**

Round 3 — Could You Have Guessed?

1. What is the "Wood Wide Web"? → **B. Underground fungal networks linking trees**
2. How many times per day does lightning strike Earth? → **C. 8 million**
3. What causes volcanic lightning? → **C. Static electricity from ash and debris**
4. How much has the North Magnetic Pole shifted since 1900 → **C. Over 1,000 km**
5. How old is the Methuselah bristlecone pine? → **C. 4,855 years**
6. How far back can ice cores measure atmospheric data? → **D. 800,000 years**
7. The 2011 Japan earthquake changed Earth's day by: → **B. 1.8 microseconds**
8. Where is the Methuselah tree located? → **C. California**
9. How many viruses are in approximately one litre of seawater? → **C. 10 million**
10. Glass is technically described as: → **C. An amorphous solid / supercooled liquid**

Round 4 — Quick Fire

1. What is the world's largest living organism? → **Pando — a clonal aspen grove in Utah (or a honey fungus in Oregon)**
2. What percentage of Earth's species live in the ocean? → **About 80% (estimated)**
3. What is the name for the underground fungal network linking trees? → **Mycorrhizal network (Wood Wide Web)**
4. What causes the Northern Lights (Aurora Borealis)? → **Charged particles from the Sun interacting with Earth's magnetic field**
5. How hot is a lightning bolt? → **About 30,000 Kelvin (5 times hotter than the Sun's surface)**

6. What is the fastest wind speed ever recorded on Earth? → **408 km/h (Barrow Island, Australia, 1996)**
7. What is the loudest natural sound ever recorded? → **The 1883 Krakatoa eruption (heard 5,000 km away)**
8. What percentage of Earth's fresh water is frozen in ice caps? → **About 69%**
9. Which type of cloud is the tallest? → **Cumulonimbus**
10. How long has life existed on Earth approximately? → **About 3.8 billion years**

Round 5 — Stump Your Friends!

1. Fungi are more closely related to which kingdom? → **C. Animals**
2. The Cambrian Explosion approximately 541 million years → **B. A rapid diversification of complex animal life**
3. What is the Coriolis effect? → **B. Deflection of moving objects due to Earth's rotation**
4. What is the albedo effect? → **B. Reflection of solar radiation by surfaces like ice**
5. The deepest point on Earth is the Challenger Deep. How → **C. 11 km**
6. What percentage of Earth's species are estimated to be → **D. 80%+**
7. Permafrost covers approximately what percentage of Earth → **B. 17%**
8. What is the most abundant mineral in Earth's mantle? → **D. Bridgmanite**
9. Ocean currents are driven primarily by: → **B. Temperature, salinity and wind**
10. The Great Oxidation Event approximately 2.4 billion years → **C. The rise of photosynthesis and oxygen in atmosphere**
11. Which gas makes up the majority of Earth's atmosphere? → **D. Nitrogen (78%)**
12. What is the name for the boundary between Earth's crust → **B. The Mohorovičić discontinuity**
13. How fast do tectonic plates typically move? → **B. 1–10 cm per year**
14. What type of rock makes up the majority of Earth's ocean → **C. Basalt**
15. The Amazon Basin contains approximately what percentage → **B. 10%**

CHAPTER 13 • UNBELIEVABLE BUT TRUE TRIVIA

Psychology & The Human Mind

Your brain is constantly lying to you — and it's doing it for very good reasons.

ROUND 1 — FACT BOMBS

Read these 10 astonishing facts carefully. Your next rounds will test whether they landed.

FACT #1

The "bystander effect" is real and documented: the more witnesses to an emergency, the less likely any individual is to help, because each person assumes someone else will act.

★ *Crowds can produce less help than a single person.*

FACT #2

You make the majority of your decisions unconsciously — neuroscience shows brain activity preparing for a decision occurs up to 10 seconds before you become consciously aware of "deciding."

★ *Your brain decides before you know you have.*

FACT #3

The Dunning-Kruger effect is one of psychology's most replicated findings: incompetent people tend to overestimate their own competence because they lack the skills to recognise their limitations.

★ *The less you know, the more confident you feel.*

FACT #4

Humans are the only animals known to experience psychological placebo effects from pills and treatments. Other animals respond to placebo only minimally, if at all.

★ *Belief is a uniquely human medicine.*

FACT #5

The phenomenon of "déjà vu" is now understood as a brief glitch in the brain's familiarity recognition system — not a memory of a past life or suppressed memory.

★ *The uncanny feeling of "I've been here before" is a misfiring neural process.*

FACT #6

A "flash bulb memory" — the vivid, specific recall you have of where you were when something dramatic happened — is often significantly inaccurate. The confidence doesn't match the accuracy.

★ *Your most vivid memories are not your most reliable.*

FACT #7

The average human has approximately 6,200 thoughts per day, according to a 2020 Queen's University study using neuroimaging — the first study to attempt to count thought transitions.

★ *Your mind never stops, even when you feel it has.*

FACT #8

Solitary confinement produces measurable psychological damage within 72 hours — including hallucinations, panic attacks, and cognitive disruption. The effects can be permanent.

★ *Isolation is a form of torture. Neuroscience confirms it.*

FACT #9

The mere exposure effect means people rate things as more likeable simply by being exposed to them repeatedly — explaining much of the power of advertising.

★ *Familiarity manufactures preference.*

FACT #10

Cognitive dissonance — holding two contradictory beliefs — is so uncomfortable that people alter their beliefs, deny evidence, or rationalise information rather than tolerate the conflict.

★ *The mind would rather change reality than feel uncomfortable.*

ROUND 2**True or False (10 statements based on the Fact Bombs • 1 pt each)**

Mark each TRUE or FALSE — all answers relate to the facts you just read.

1. The bystander effect means more witnesses leads to less likelihood of individual help.
TRUE / FALSE
2. Brain activity preparing for a decision can occur up to 10 seconds before conscious awareness.
TRUE / FALSE
3. The Dunning-Kruger effect describes how highly skilled people underestimate their ability.
TRUE / FALSE
4. Déjà vu is now understood as a glitch in familiarity recognition.
TRUE / FALSE
5. Flashbulb memories are consistently more accurate than ordinary memories.
TRUE / FALSE
6. Humans average approximately 6,200 thoughts per day.
TRUE / FALSE
7. Solitary confinement begins causing psychological damage within 72 hours.
TRUE / FALSE
8. The mere exposure effect means we dislike things we see repeatedly.
TRUE / FALSE
9. Cognitive dissonance is the comfort of holding two consistent beliefs.
TRUE / FALSE
10. Only humans are known to experience psychological placebo effects significantly.
TRUE / FALSE

ROUND 3**Could You Have Guessed? (10 multiple choice questions • 1 pt each)**

Four options — only one is correct.

1. The Dunning-Kruger effect describes:

- A. Experts doubting themselves
- B. Incompetent people overestimating ability
- C. Smart people ignoring their limits
- D. Memory distortion in trauma

2. Approximately how many thoughts does a human have per day?

- A. 600
- B. 2,000
- C. 6,200
- D. 60,000

3. What causes déjà vu according to current neuroscience?

- A. Suppressed memory surfacing
- B. Past life recall
- C. Familiarity recognition glitch
- D. Sleep deprivation

4. The bystander effect was first formally studied after which event?

- A. A plane crash
- B. The Kitty Genovese murder (1964)
- C. A public drowning
- D. A subway attack

5. Brain activity preparing decisions precedes conscious awareness by up to:

- A. 1 second
- B. 3 seconds
- C. 10 seconds
- D. 30 seconds

6. Psychological harm from solitary confinement begins in approximately:

- A. 24 hours
- B. 72 hours
- C. 1 week
- D. 1 month

7. The mere exposure effect explains:

- A. Why new things are exciting

- B. The power of repetition in advertising
 - C. How trauma creates memory
 - D. Why strangers seem threatening
- 8. Cognitive dissonance occurs when:**
- A. Two memories conflict
 - B. You hold contradictory beliefs simultaneously
 - C. A belief is challenged by authority
 - D. Sleep disturbs thought patterns
- 9. Flashbulb memories are characterised by:**
- A. High accuracy
 - B. High confidence but often inaccuracy
 - C. Being completely false
 - D. Only occurring in trauma
- 10. Placebo effects require what key element?**
- A. The right drug chemistry
 - B. Real medical treatment nearby
 - C. Belief that treatment is effective
 - D. Medical supervision

ROUND 4**Quick Fire (10 short-answer questions · 1 pt each)**

No options. Write your answer from memory.

- 1.** Who developed the theory of psychoanalysis?

Answer:

- 2.** What is the term for irrational fear of spiders?

Answer:

- 3.** What is cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT)?

Answer:

- 4.** What is Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs?

Answer:

- 5.** What is the name for the inability to feel pleasure?

Answer:

- 6.** What does IQ stand for?

Answer:

- 7.** Which psychologist conducted the famous "obedience to authority" experiments?

Answer:

- 8.** What is the amygdala responsible for?

Answer:

- 9.** What is confirmation bias?

Answer:

- 10.** What is the term for the brain's ability to change and adapt?

Answer:

ROUND 5**Stump Your Friends! (15 harder questions · 1 pt each)**

The round that separates the curious from the truly knowledgeable. No mercy.

- 1. Milgram's obedience experiments found that approximately what percentage of participants gave maximum electric shocks?**
 - A. 25%
 - B. 45%
 - C. 65%
 - D. 85%
- 2. Which psychologist conducted the Stanford Prison Experiment?**
 - A. Milgram
 - B. Zimbardo
 - C. Skinner
 - D. Bandura
- 3. What is the name for the psychological tendency to attribute others' behaviour to character rather than situation?**
 - A. Confirmation bias
 - B. Fundamental attribution error
 - C. Actor-observer bias
 - D. Self-serving bias
- 4. Operant conditioning was developed by:**
 - A. Pavlov
 - B. Freud
 - C. Skinner
 - D. Jung
- 5. Classical conditioning was famously demonstrated by:**
 - A. Pavlov (dogs)
 - B. Skinner (rats)
 - C. Milgram (humans)
 - D. Bandura (children)
- 6. What is the "halo effect"?**
 - A. Assuming beautiful people are smarter
 - B. One positive trait influencing overall judgement
 - C. Overrating familiar things
 - D. Underestimating risk from attractive sources
- 7. Sunk cost fallacy refers to:**

- A. Investing in failing projects due to past investment
 - B. Overvaluing future gains
 - C. Undervaluing present resources
 - D. Ignoring opportunity cost
- 8. Which part of the brain is associated with executive function and decision-making?**
- A. Amygdala
 - B. Cerebellum
 - C. Prefrontal cortex
 - D. Hippocampus
- 9. What is the availability heuristic?**
- A. Using the most familiar option
 - B. Judging likelihood based on how easily examples come to mind
 - C. Deferring to authority on decisions
 - D. Preferring certain smaller rewards over uncertain larger ones
- 10. Attachment theory was developed by:**
- A. Freud
 - B. Ainsworth and Bowlby
 - C. Erikson
 - D. Vygotsky
- 11. What is the "dark triad" of personality traits?**
- A. Depression, anxiety, paranoia
 - B. Narcissism, Machiavellianism, psychopathy
 - C. Arrogance, selfishness, coldness
 - D. Dominance, control, manipulation
- 12. What does the term "locus of control" measure?**
- A. Brain region for emotion
 - B. Whether someone believes they control their outcomes
 - C. Response time in decision-making
 - D. Social influence on choices
- 13. Which psychologist developed the hierarchy of needs?**
- A. Rogers
 - B. Frankl
 - C. Maslow
 - D. Erikson
- 14. What is the Stroop effect?**
- A. Memory improving with sleep

- B. Difficulty naming ink colour of conflicting colour words
- C. Brain prioritising visual over auditory
- D. Cognitive load reducing memory

15. Ego depletion theory suggests that:

- A. Willpower is unlimited
- B. Self-control is a finite resource that depletes with use
- C. Intelligence decreases under stress
- D. Decision-making improves with fatigue

MY SCORE: Round 1: ____ /10 Round 2: ____ /10 Round 3: ____ /10
Round 4: ____ /15 **TOTAL: ____/45**

CHAPTER CLOSE *Your mind is not a neutral recorder of reality. It is an active, opinionated, self-serving system that edits everything you experience. Understanding that is not discouraging — it is the beginning of genuine wisdom.*

CHAPTER 13 — ANSWER KEY

Round 2 — True or False

1. The bystander effect means more witnesses leads to less like... → **TRUE**
2. Brain activity preparing for a decision can occur up to 10 s... → **TRUE**
3. The Dunning-Kruger effect describes how highly skilled peopl... → **FALSE**
4. Déjà vu is now understood as a glitch in familiarity recogni... → **TRUE**
5. Flashbulb memories are consistently more accurate than ordin... → **FALSE**
6. Humans average approximately 6,200 thoughts per day.... → **TRUE**
7. Solitary confinement begins causing psychological damage wit... → **TRUE**
8. The mere exposure effect means we dislike things we see repe... → **FALSE**
9. Cognitive dissonance is the comfort of holding two consisten... → **FALSE**
10. Only humans are known to experience psychological placebo ef... → **TRUE**

Round 3 — Could You Have Guessed?

1. The Dunning-Kruger effect describes: → **B. Incompetent people overestimating ability**
2. Approximately how many thoughts does a human have per d → **C. 6,200**
3. What causes déjà vu according to current neuroscience? → **C. Familiarity recognition glitch**
4. The bystander effect was first formally studied after w → **B. The Kitty Genovese murder (1964)**
5. Brain activity preparing decisions precedes conscious a → **C. 10 seconds**
6. Psychological harm from solitary confinement begins in → **B. 72 hours**
7. The mere exposure effect explains: → **B. The power of repetition in advertising**
8. Cognitive dissonance occurs when: → **B. You hold contradictory beliefs simultaneously**
9. Flashbulb memories are characterised by: → **B. High confidence but often inaccuracy**
10. Placebo effects require what key element? → **C. Belief that treatment is effective**

Round 4 — Quick Fire

1. Who developed the theory of psychoanalysis? → **Sigmund Freud**
2. What is the term for irrational fear of spiders? → **Arachnophobia**
3. What is cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT)? → **A therapy that addresses unhelpful thoughts and behaviours**
4. What is Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs? → **A motivational theory of human needs from basic (survival) to self-actualisation**
5. What is the name for the inability to feel pleasure? → **Anhedonia**
6. What does IQ stand for? → **Intelligence Quotient**

7. Which psychologist conducted the famous "obedience to authority" experiments? → **Stanley Milgram**
8. What is the amygdala responsible for? → **Emotional processing, especially fear responses**
9. What is confirmation bias? → **The tendency to seek information that confirms existing beliefs**
10. What is the term for the brain's ability to change and adapt? → **Neuroplasticity**

Round 5 — Stump Your Friends!

1. Milgram's obedience experiments found that approximatel → **C. 65%**
2. Which psychologist conducted the Stanford Prison Experi → **B. Zimbardo**
3. What is the name for the psychological tendency to attr → **B. Fundamental attribution error**
4. Operant conditioning was developed by: → **C. Skinner**
5. Classical conditioning was famously demonstrated by: → **A. Pavlov (dogs)**
6. What is the "halo effect"? → **B. One positive trait influencing overall judgement**
7. Sunk cost fallacy refers to: → **A. Investing in failing projects due to past investment**
8. Which part of the brain is associated with executive fu → **C. Prefrontal cortex**
9. What is the availability heuristic? → **B. Judging likelihood based on how easily examples come to mind**
10. Attachment theory was developed by: → **B. Ainsworth and Bowlby**
11. What is the "dark triad" of personality traits? → **B. Narcissism, Machiavellianism, psychopathy**
12. What does the term "locus of control" measure? → **B. Whether someone believes they control their outcomes**
13. Which psychologist developed the hierarchy of needs? → **C. Maslow**
14. What is the Stroop effect? → **B. Difficulty naming ink colour of conflicting colour words**
15. Ego depletion theory suggests that: → **B. Self-control is a finite resource that depletes with use**

CHAPTER 14 • UNBELIEVABLE BUT TRUE TRIVIA

The World in Numbers — Statistics That Shatter Assumptions

Most of your intuitions about the world are wrong. The numbers say so — and the numbers are not what you expect.

ROUND 1 — FACT BOMBS

Read these 10 astonishing facts carefully. Your next rounds will test whether they landed.

FACT #1

If the entire history of Earth were compressed into a single 24-hour day, modern humans would appear in the last 3 seconds before midnight. Agriculture would appear in the last 0.3 seconds.

★ *Everything you've ever known fits in the final fraction of a cosmic second.*

FACT #2

Every human alive today is descended from a common female ancestor — known as "Mitochondrial Eve" — who lived approximately 150,000–200,000 years ago in Africa.

★ *Everyone on Earth is your distant relative.*

FACT #3

If you folded a piece of paper 42 times, it would be thick enough to reach the Moon. If you folded it 103 times, it would be larger than the observable universe.

★ *Exponential growth is almost incomprehensible.*

FACT #4

The number of possible games of chess exceeds the number of atoms in the observable universe. The Shannon number (10^{120}) dwarfs the estimated 10^{80} atoms in existence.

★ *Chess is larger than reality.*

FACT #5

In 1900, the average life expectancy worldwide was 32 years. By 2023 it had risen to approximately 73 years — more than doubled in 120 years.

★ *Humanity aged two years every decade of the 20th century.*

FACT #6

If you earn \$34,000 per year, you are in the top 1% of earners globally. Most people in wealthy nations don't realise how affluent they are by global standards.

★ *You may be richer than you think.*

FACT #7

More people were killed by mosquitoes last year than by any other animal — including humans. Mosquitoes are responsible for approximately 725,000 human deaths annually.

★ *The deadliest animal is the size of a fingernail.*

FACT #8

The global population reached 1 billion in approximately 1804. It took 123 years to reach 2 billion. It reached 8 billion in 2022 — in 1/10th of that time.

★ *Population growth is an exponential curve, not a straight line.*

FACT #9

Reading speed: the average adult reads approximately 238 words per minute. At that speed, reading every book in the US Library of Congress (over 17 million books) would take over 80,000 years.

★ *There is more human knowledge than any single human can absorb.*

FACT #10

Light pollution is so widespread that one third of the world's population — including 60% of Europeans and 80% of North Americans — cannot see the Milky Way from where they live.

★ *The night sky that inspired every ancient civilisation is now invisible to most people.*

ROUND 2**True or False (10 statements based on the Fact Bombs • 1 pt each)**

Mark each TRUE or FALSE — all answers relate to the facts you just read.

1. Modern humans appear in the last 3 seconds of a 24-hour Earth history.

TRUE / FALSE

2. "Mitochondrial Eve" lived approximately 150,000–200,000 years ago.

TRUE / FALSE

3. Folding paper 42 times would reach the Moon.

TRUE / FALSE

4. The number of possible chess games is smaller than the number of atoms in the universe.

TRUE / FALSE

5. Global life expectancy in 1900 was approximately 32 years.

TRUE / FALSE

6. Earning \$34,000 per year puts you in the global top 10%, not top 1%.

TRUE / FALSE

7. Mosquitoes kill more people annually than any other animal including humans.

TRUE / FALSE

8. Global population reached 1 billion around 1804.

TRUE / FALSE

9. The average adult reads approximately 238 words per minute.

TRUE / FALSE

10. Most Europeans can see the Milky Way from their homes.

TRUE / FALSE

ROUND 3**Could You Have Guessed? (10 multiple choice questions • 1 pt each)**

Four options — only one is correct.

1. How many times must you fold paper to reach the Moon?

- A. 10
 - B. 25
 - C. 42
 - D. 100
- 2. What is the Shannon number?**
- A. Atoms in the universe
 - B. Possible chess games (10^{120})
 - C. Stars in the Milky Way
 - D. DNA base pairs in a human
- 3. What was global average life expectancy in 1900?**
- A. 22 years
 - B. 32 years
 - C. 45 years
 - D. 55 years
- 4. Earning \$34,000/year places you in which global percentile?**
- A. Top 10%
 - B. Top 5%
 - C. Top 1%
 - D. Top 0.1%
- 5. How many people are killed by mosquitoes annually?**
- A. 100,000
 - B. 250,000
 - C. 725,000
 - D. 2 million
- 6. When did global population reach 1 billion?**
- A. 1750
 - B. 1804
 - C. 1850
 - D. 1900
- 7. What percentage of North Americans can't see the Milky Way?**
- A. 40%
 - B. 60%
 - C. 80%
 - D. 95%
- 8. "Mitochondrial Eve" refers to:**
- A. The first woman on Earth

- B.** A common female ancestor of all living humans
- C.** A genetic mutation
- D.** The oldest known human fossil

9. How long would reading every Library of Congress book take at average speed?

- A.** 8,000 years
- B.** 25,000 years
- C.** 80,000 years
- D.** 500,000 years

10. What was global population in 2022?

- A.** 6 billion
- B.** 7 billion
- C.** 8 billion
- D.** 9 billion

ROUND 4**Quick Fire (10 short-answer questions · 1 pt each)**

No options. Write your answer from memory.

- 1.** What percentage of the human genome do all humans share?

Answer:

- 2.** How many cells are in the human body approximately?

Answer:

- 3.** What fraction of Earth's species are insects?

Answer:

- 4.** How many neurons are in the human brain approximately?

Answer:

- 5.** What percentage of Earth's fresh water is drinkable?

Answer:

- 6.** How fast is the universe expanding?

Answer:

- 7.** What percentage of species that have ever existed on Earth are now extinct?

Answer:

- 8.** How many languages are endangered (fewer than 1,000 speakers)?

Answer:

- 9.** What is the average depth of the world's oceans?

Answer:

- 10.** How many books are published worldwide annually?

Answer:

ROUND 5

Stump Your Friends! (15 harder questions · 1 pt each)

The round that separates the curious from the truly knowledgeable. No mercy.

- 1. What is the probability of being born as a specific individual person?**
 - A. 1 in 400 trillion
 - B. 1 in 4 quadrillion
 - C. 1 in 400 quadrillion
 - D. Incalculably small
- 2. If human history is 200,000 years, what percentage happened before writing?**
 - A. 50%
 - B. 75%
 - C. 90%
 - D. 97%+
- 3. The observable universe contains approximately how many galaxies?**
 - A. 200 billion
 - B. 2 trillion
 - C. 200 trillion
 - D. 2 quadrillion
- 4. At current growth rates, how many people will live on Earth by 2100 (UN estimate)?**
 - A. 9 billion
 - B. 10.4 billion
 - C. 12 billion
 - D. 15 billion
- 5. How many data points does the global internet process per second (approximately)?**
 - A. Millions
 - B. Billions
 - C. Trillions
 - D. Quintillions
- 6. The probability of winning the UK National Lottery jackpot is approximately 1 in:**
 - A. 500,000
 - B. 5 million
 - C. 45 million

- D. 450 million
- 7. What fraction of all money in existence is physical cash?**
- A. 50%
 - B. 30%
 - C. 10%
 - D. Less than 8%
- 8. How much data was created in 2023 (approximately)?**
- A. 20 zettabytes
 - B. 50 zettabytes
 - C. 120 zettabytes
 - D. 1,000 zettabytes
- 9. The half-life of facts in medicine — time before half of medical knowledge is outdated — is approximately:**
- A. 1 year
 - B. 5 years
 - C. 18–45 years depending on field
 - D. 100 years
- 10. What percentage of human communication is estimated to be non-verbal?**
- A. 20%
 - B. 40%
 - C. 60%
 - D. 70–93% depending on study
- 11. If every human on Earth held hands in a line, how many times would it wrap around the equator?**
- A. 2 times
 - B. 7 times
 - C. 30 times
 - D. 300 times
- 12. How many species are estimated to go extinct each day?**
- A. 1
 - B. 10
 - C. 100–150
 - D. 1,000
- 13. What percentage of the ocean floor has been mapped in high resolution?**

- A. 5%
- B. 20%
- C. 50%
- D. 80%

14. The Great Pacific Garbage Patch is approximately how large?

- A. The size of Texas
- B. Twice the size of Texas
- C. The size of France
- D. Twice the size of France

15. What fraction of Earth's land surface is used for agriculture?

- A. 10%
- B. 25%
- C. 38%
- D. 50%

MY SCORE: Round 1: ____ /10 Round 2: ____ /10 Round 3: ____ /10
Round 4: ____ /10 **TOTAL: ____/45**

CHAPTER CLOSE *Numbers reveal what intuition hides. The world is simultaneously more extraordinary, more fragile, more connected, and more dangerous than everyday experience suggests. Statistics are not dry — they are the closest thing we have to truth about the world at scale.*

CHAPTER 14 — ANSWER KEY

Round 2 — True or False

1. Modern humans appear in the last 3 seconds of a 24-hour Earth... → **TRUE**
2. "Mitochondrial Eve" lived approximately 150,000–200,000 years... → **TRUE**
3. Folding paper 42 times would reach the Moon.... → **TRUE**
4. The number of possible chess games is smaller than the number of stars in the Milky Way... → **FALSE**
5. Global life expectancy in 1900 was approximately 32 years.... → **TRUE**
6. Earning \$34,000 per year puts you in the global top 10%, not... → **FALSE**
7. Mosquitoes kill more people annually than any other animal... → **TRUE**
8. Global population reached 1 billion around 1804.... → **TRUE**
9. The average adult reads approximately 238 words per minute.... → **TRUE**
10. Most Europeans can see the Milky Way from their homes.... → **FALSE**

Round 3 — Could You Have Guessed?

1. How many times must you fold paper to reach the Moon? → **C. 42**
2. What is the Shannon number? → **B. Possible chess games (10^{120})**
3. What was global average life expectancy in 1900? → **B. 32 years**
4. Earning \$34,000/year places you in which global percent? → **C. Top 1%**
5. How many people are killed by mosquitoes annually? → **C. 725,000**
6. When did global population reach 1 billion? → **B. 1804**
7. What percentage of North Americans can't see the Milky Way? → **C. 80%**
8. "Mitochondrial Eve" refers to: → **B. A common female ancestor of all living humans**
9. How long would reading every Library of Congress book take? → **C. 80,000 years**
10. What was global population in 2022? → **C. 8 billion**

Round 4 — Quick Fire

1. What percentage of the human genome do all humans share? → **Approximately 99.9%**
2. How many cells are in the human body approximately? → **About 37 trillion**
3. What fraction of Earth's species are insects? → **About 80% of all animal species**
4. How many neurons are in the human brain approximately? → **About 86 billion**
5. What percentage of Earth's fresh water is drinkable? → **About 0.3% (most is frozen or underground)**
6. How fast is the universe expanding? → **Approximately 67–70 km/s per megaparsec (accelerating)**
7. What percentage of species that have ever existed on Earth are now extinct? → **Over 99%**

8. How many languages are endangered (fewer than 1,000 speakers)? → **About 40% of the world's 7,000 languages**
9. What is the average depth of the world's oceans? → **Approximately 3.7 km (3,700 metres)**
10. How many books are published worldwide annually? → **Approximately 2.2 million books per year**

Round 5 — Stump Your Friends!

1. What is the probability of being born as a specific ind → **D. Incalculably small**
2. If human history is 200,000 years, what percentage happ → **D. 97%+**
3. The observable universe contains approximately how many → **B. 2 trillion**
4. At current growth rates, how many people will live on E → **B. 10.4 billion**
5. How many data points does the global internet process p → **D. Quintillions**
6. The probability of winning the UK National Lottery jack → **C. 45 million**
7. What fraction of all money in existence is physical cas → **D. Less than 8%**
8. How much data was created in 2023 (approximately)? → **C. 120 zettabytes**
9. The half-life of facts in medicine — time before half o → **C. 18–45 years depending on field**
10. What percentage of human communication is estimated to → **D. 70–93% depending on study**
11. If every human on Earth held hands in a line, how many → **B. 7 times**
12. How many species are estimated to go extinct each day? → **C. 100–150**
13. What percentage of the ocean floor has been mapped in h → **B. 20%**
14. The Great Pacific Garbage Patch is approximately how la → **B. Twice the size of Texas**
15. What fraction of Earth's land surface is used for agric → **C. 38%**

Your Final Score

Add up your chapter totals below to find your Knowledge Rank.

- 01. The Animal Kingdom _____ / 45
- 02. The Human Body _____ / 45
- 03. Space & The Cosmos _____ / 45
- 04. History's Greatest Surprises _____ / 45
- 05. Science's Most Shocking Discoveries _____ / 45
- 06. Food & Drink — The Unbelievable Truth _____ / 45
- 07. Language, Words & Communication _____ / 45
- 08. Money, Power & Economics _____ / 45
- 09. Famous Minds & Their Surprising Lives _____ / 45
- 10. Geography's Greatest Surprises _____ / 45
- 11. Pop Culture's Hidden Truth _____ / 45
- 12. The Natural World's Strangest Secrets _____ / 45
- 13. Psychology & The Human Mind _____ / 45
- 14. The World in Numbers — Statistics That Shatter Assumptions _____ / 45

GRAND TOTAL _____ / **630**

- 567–630** ★★★★★ **GRAND MASTER**
- 504–566** ★★★★★ **KNOWLEDGE CHAMPION**
- 378–503** ★★★★★ **CURIOUS SCHOLAR**
- 252–377** ★★★★★ **KEEN LEARNER**
- Below 252** ★★★★★ **APPRENTICE**

FEEDBACK & CONTACT *Enjoyed the challenge? Share your feedback at snappgrid.com/contact.*

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